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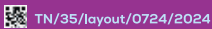
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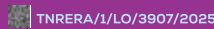
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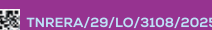
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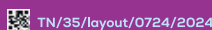
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STEPPING UP
Nishant, son of Bihar CM Nitish, joins JD(U)
NEWS » PAGE 11

STORMY AGENDA
Budget Session resumes today with debate on Birla's removal
NEWS » PAGE 11





VIOLENT OUTBURST
Student kills hostel inmate in Karnataka
SOUTH » PAGE 7

ONE NATION, ONE ELECTION
Remedy worse than disease
Proposal undermines federalism and voter mandate, says Stalin
EDITORIAL » PAGE 8



NEW KING
Lin denies Lakshya the All England title
SPORT » PAGE 16

Centre seeks report from Bengal on President's visit

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A day after President Droupadi Murmu expressed disappointment over the Mamata Banerjee government's arrangements for the International Santal Conference in Darjeeling, the Union Home Ministry on Sunday sought a report from the West Bengal Chief Secretary on the alleged violations of protocol laid down in the "Blue Book" and poor security arrangements during the President's visit.

Union Home Secretary Govind Mohan asked West Bengal Chief Secretary Nandini Chakravorty to submit the report detailing the violations of protocol and lapses in security arrangements along the President's motorcade route and at the venue by 5 p.m. on Sunday, a government source said.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday ac-



Protocol matters: President Droupadi Murmu at the International Santal Conference in Darjeeling, West Bengal, on Saturday. ANI

cused the Trinamool Congress of insulting the President, the Constitution, and democratic principles. Speaking in New Delhi, Mr. Modi said the "arrogant politics" of the Trinamool Congress would soon be defeated. Terming the treatment meted out to the President in the poll-bound State "heart-wrenching", Mr. Modi alleged the Trinamool government did not make proper arrangements for the event. "This is an insult

to the President, the Constitution and its spirit, and the democratic principles of the country," he said, adding that the Trinamool also insulted the "mothers and sisters" of the country. "It has been noted that those who are extremely arrogant and drunk in power are ultimately destroyed," Mr. Modi said.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10
BJP SLAMS MAMATA
» PAGE 11

India routs New Zealand, defends T20 World Cup

Men in Blue beat Black Caps by 96 runs with a stellar batting show complemented by Bumrah's four-for; Samson, Abhishek, Kishan score 50s; Dube's cameo pushes Suryakumar's men past 250

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
AHMEDABAD

India kept its date with cricketing history as Suryakumar Yadav's men claimed the ICC T20 World Cup with a stirring display at the Narendra Modi Stadium here on Sunday. In a one-sided summit clash against New Zealand, India's batting might allied with a bowling featuring the genius of Jasprit Bumrah, proved too steep a hurdle for the Black Caps.

Having won the title in 2024, the Men in Blue retained the championship through a terrific campaign with the lone blemish being the loss against South Africa in the Super Eight.

After New Zealand elected to field, the host's top-order of Sanju Samson



On top of the world: Indian players celebrate the 2026 ICC T20 World Cup victory after beating New Zealand in the final at the Narendra Modi Stadium in Ahmedabad on Sunday. EMMANUAL YOGINI

(89), Abhishek Sharma, and Ishan Kishan came to the fore, while Shivam Dube's last-over heroics helped India post 255 for five. New Zealand, which humbled South Africa in the semifinal, failed to re-

plicate that batting endeavour. Reduced to 47 for three in the initial part of the chase, Mitchell Santner's men were forced to play catch-up for the rest of the final. Bumrah's four for 15, Kishan's catches, and

overall energy levels propelled India while New Zealand was bowled out for 159, as the hosts sealed their victory by 96 runs.

MORE REPORTS ON
» PAGE 15

NEARBY



AIADMK 'traitors' will cause DMK's downfall: EPS

ERODE
AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami on Sunday said the ruling DMK would face consequences for associating itself with several "traitors" expelled from the AIADMK. **» PAGE 6**

T.N. panel to draft rules to regulate hostile dog breeds

CHENNAI
The Tamil Nadu government has constituted an expert committee to frame rules to regulate or ban aggressive dog breeds in the interest of public safety. **» PAGE 6**

EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 2

New Supreme Leader decided: Iran; U.S., Israel strike Tehran fuel depots

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN/DUBAI

Iran was preparing to reveal its new Supreme Leader on Sunday, even as U.S.-backed Israeli air strikes destroyed fuel dumps and triggered fires that choked much of Tehran in a thick blanket of smoke.

The fuel depot strikes are the first time Iranian oil infrastructure has been targeted during the ongoing conflict. While Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian said on Saturday that the Islamic Republic will not strike its West Asian neighbours unless attacks originated from their territory, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Kuwait, and Bahrain all reported new attacks on Sunday.



Iranian civil defence members next to a destroyed fuel tanker after an air strike on the Shahran oil refinery in Tehran on Sunday. AFP

An Indian national was among two killed in Saudi Arabia where a military projectile fell into a residential area in Al Kharj governorate, the Kingdom's civil defence said on Sunday without identifying the victims.

Iran's clerical body tasked with choosing a suc-

cessor to Ayatollah Ali Khamenei — who was killed just over a week ago in the strikes that triggered the war — has reached a decision, but is yet to name the new leader.

"The vote to appoint the leader has taken place and the leader has been chosen," said Ahmad Alamol-

hoda, a member of the Assembly of Experts, as quoted by Iran's Mehr news agency.

Mr. Alamolhoda said the secretariat of the body would announce the name later.

Khamenei's name as Iran's leader will continue, Hosseinali Eshkevari, another member of the Assembly, said on Sunday.

U.S. President Donald Trump warned on Sunday that Iran's next Supreme Leader would not last long without his approval, while Israel said its forces would not hesitate to target the new chief and members of the council that met to confirm him.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

Rules not ready for new rural job Act

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

The Viksit Bharat — Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) Act, 2025, has several steps to clear before it can be implemented.

According to sources, the Union Rural Development Ministry is holding weekly consultation meetings with the State governments.

There are several tricky issues that the Centre must navigate, including a formula for "normative allocation" for the States. The objective parameters for this are yet to be finalised. Under the legislation,

Rough edges

The Centre has to frame rules under 11 categories before implementation of the VB-G RAM G Act

■ According to Section 4(5) of the Act, the Centre will determine State-wise normative allocation based on 'objective parameters'

■ Parameters also needed to categorise Gram Panchayats based on development

these may be prescribed by the Union government.

The Union government has to frame rules under 11 categories, for example on social audit of the scheme.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

Man dies in police custody in Sivaganga

C. Palanivel Rajan
SIVAGANGA

A 26-year-old man, who was picked up by the police in an assault case and allegedly tortured in custody at Manamadurai in Sivaganga district, died while undergoing treatment on Sunday.

The victim was R. Akash Delison, an engineering graduate belonging to a Scheduled Caste community. Sources said the Manamadurai police had arrested Akash and his acquaintance Guna, both from Manamadurai, two days ago for allegedly attacking P. Jayakumar, 37, and R. Azhagar, 40, with sharp weapons and inflict-

ing injuries on them.

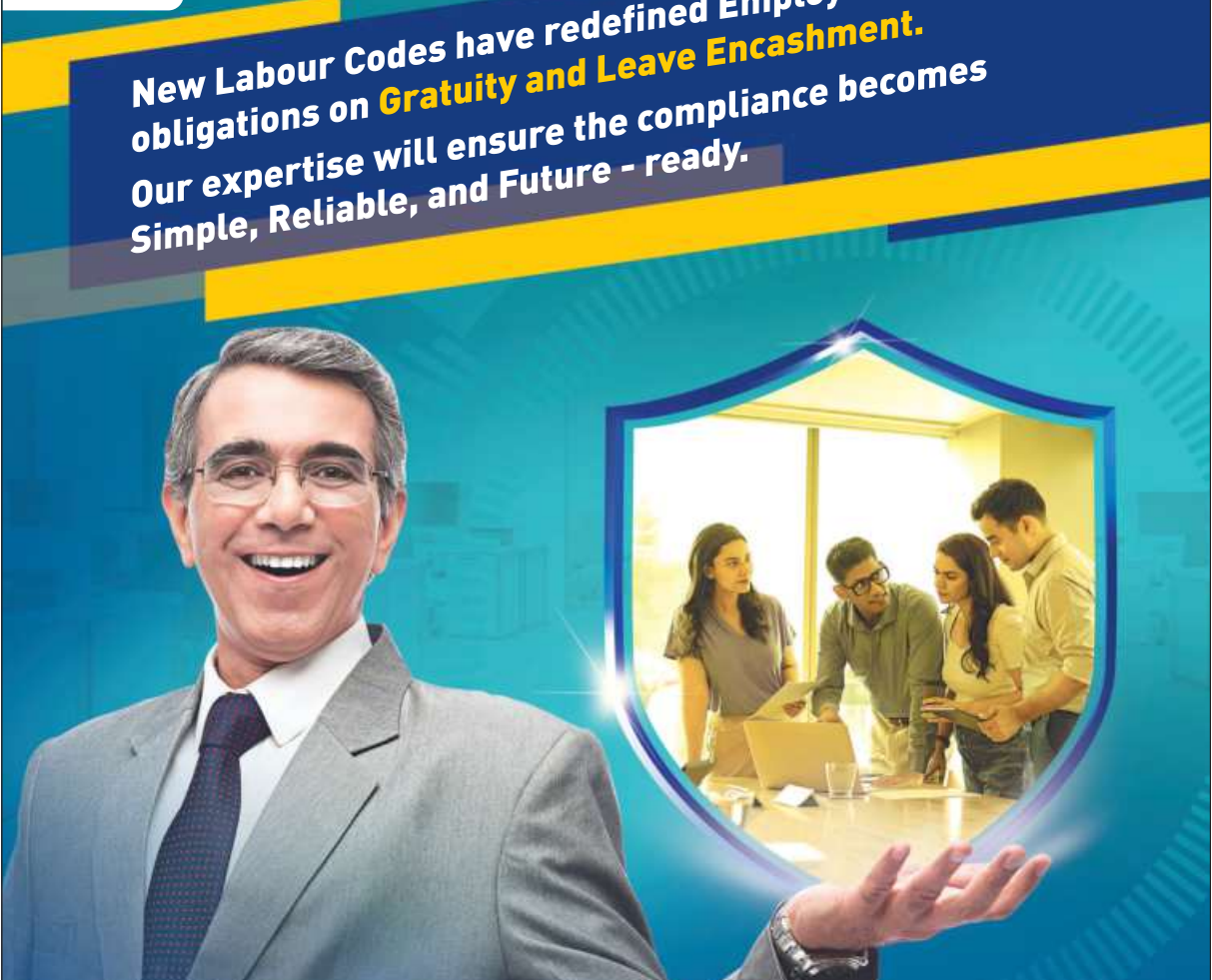
Based on a complaint from Azhagar, a case was registered at the Manamadurai police station under Sections 324(2), 296(b), 118(1), 109(1), and 351(3) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita on March 6.

The police said Akash was a history-sheeter facing three cases under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act, 1985, and a case of attempt to murder. In a statement, the Sivaganga district police said Azhagar and Akash belonged to the same community and knew each other.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 6



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M CH-CH

Sri Lankan Tamil murdered at camp in Gummidipoondi; six persons arrested

The victim was the chairman of the management committee of the rehabilitation camp; he was walking inside the camp when three persons picked a quarrel with him and assaulted him with an iron rod; two women among those arrested by the police

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A tense situation prevailed in the Sri Lankan Tamil Rehabilitation camp in Gummidipoondi after the chairman of the camp's management committee was murdered by a gang on Saturday night.

The Tiruvallur district police secured six persons of a family within a few hours of the murder and deployed more than 100 police personnel to prevent any further

er clash in the locality.

A senior police officer said Sivakumar, alias Kanna, was the chairman of the camp management committee of the Sri Lankan Tamil rehabilitation camp located in Pethikuppam near Gummidipoondi.

Personal enmity

More than 3,000 people reside in the camp. On Saturday night, Sivakumar was walking in the camp when three persons, including brothers Mahendran and Selva, who had personal enmity



Sivakumar, alias Kanna

with him picked a quarrel and assaulted him with an iron rod. Sivakumar tried to escape from the place but

fell unconscious on the spot in a pool of blood.

On being alerted, the Gummidipoondi police came to the spot and sent him to the government hospital in the area, where he was pronounced brought dead. Immediately, they also informed the SIPCOT Police under whose jurisdiction the camp falls.

Two arrested from camp

Later, the police sent the body to the Ponneri Government Hospital for postmortem. The police arrested six

persons, including two women, Pushpa Jothi and Akshaya, who are residents of the camp.

The dispute was over the allotment of a newly constructed house, which was recently inaugurated by Chief Minister M.K. Stalin, to one of the brothers, said police sources.

The murder led to a group of residents damaging the house of the suspects and staging a road roko on the GNT Road on Sunday, resulting in traffic being affected for a few hours.

Former Puducherry MP files PIL plea for early conduct of local body polls in UT.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Former Puducherry MP M. Ramadass has filed a public interest litigation petition in the Madras High Court seeking a direction to the State Election Commission to conduct local body polls in the Union Territory within a time frame to be fixed by the court.

The court permitted Government Pleader S. Raveekumar to take notice on behalf of the Government of Puducherry and ordered notice, returnable by March 27, to the State Election Commission. Election Commission of India standing counsel Nirajan Rajagopal accepted notice for the poll body.



M. Ramadass

In his affidavit, the 77-year-old petitioner, who served as Puducherry MP during 2004-09, said even the French rulers of the region had recognised the role of local bodies in democratic governance and therefore, created people-elected com-

The Madras High Court orders notices to Puducherry government and State Election Commission

munes and municipalities as organs of grassroot democracy before the Union Territory was liberated in 1954. However, this practice continued only till 1968.

‘No elections since 1968’

“There were no elections to these bodies after 1968, and they were kept under back burner for 38 years for reasons best known only to the members elected to the Legislative Assembly. A government ruled by the representatives of the people wilfully

and deliberately violated all the constitutional provisions,” he lamented.

The petitioner said it was only after he drew the attention of Parliament to the issue that the local body elections were finally conducted in Puducherry in 2006, leading to the election of 1,028 representatives to 10 municipalities, 10 commune panchayats and 108 village panchayats.

After their tenure ended in 2011, the Union Territory had not witnessed local body polls till date for one reason or the other, the petitioner said, and insisted on early completion of the ongoing work of assessing the quantum of reservation to be provided to the Other Backward Classes.

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I. B. Padmapriya, wife of Thiru J. Dinesh, born on 7th June 1986 (District of Birth: Madurai), residing at No. 14/8, 11th Cross Street, Shastri Nagar, Adyar, Chennai-600 020, shall henceforth be known as D. PADMAPRIYA - B. PADMAPRIYA

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Akhilesh Aver

Indian students aspiring for academic careers often enter graduate programmes excited about “finally doing real research”, only to realise that it demands far more than they expected. Unlike undergraduate coursework, where projects come with predefined topics and structured guidelines, advanced research requires students to frame their own questions, design experiments, analyse unfamiliar datasets, think critically, navigate ethical protocols and communicate findings with clarity.

Difficult transition

This transition is especially difficult in a system where scientific temper, a value rooted in critical inquiry, evidence-based thinking and curiosity-led learning, is not cultivated early or consistently. Many students encounter real research expectations much later than their international peers, which makes the leap into rigorous academic work challenging. This raises a critical question: Are Indian students entering the global academic landscape without adequate preparation?

A 2023 survey found that undergraduate exposure to research remains significantly lower than postgraduate training. Another study among medical undergraduates revealed that only one in four had the opportunity to participate in practical

Rethinking research readiness

Are Indian universities preparing students for the world of academia?

GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

research. The first meaningful experience with research began only during Master's programmes, slowing skill development and denting confidence.

One reason is the theory-heavy nature of many undergraduate programmes. Students learn scientific concepts but rarely engage in hands-on experimentation, data interpretation, or problem-solving. Practical work deepens understanding and builds abilities such as applying knowledge to real problems and transferring skills across disciplines.

Surveys also show that students value practical research exposure and want more opportunities.

Wide variation

Pockets of excellence are limited. India has more than 43,000 institutes offering undergraduate and postgraduate degrees but only a fraction are research-intensive or offer structured research opportunities for undergraduates. As a result, early research preparedness varies widely across the country. Even where training programmes exist, students

report the need for more comprehensive and up-to-date workshops. Thus, India has a vast pool of talented students but systemic gaps in early research exposure affect their academic progression and global competitiveness.

India has long grappled with brain drain with limited opportunities, outdated infrastructure, and insufficient research funding contributing to this outflow. Countries like China show this trend can be reversed. Through initiatives such as Thousand Talents

Plan (TTP), scientists were provided with generous financial incentives, world-class research facilities, elite school options and a highly supportive environment, significantly boosting the country's technological and research capabilities. India can also create conducive research environments that offer strong funding, modern infrastructure and long-term career incentives to retain and attract talent.

International postgraduate programmes typically assume that undergraduates possess a baseline of

research readiness including experimental design, troubleshooting, academic writing, and familiarity with ethics. This puts many Indian students at a disadvantage, not because of lack of capability but because the education structure historically placed less emphasis on early research training.

However, the landscape is changing. In recent years, institutions and policymakers have shown a clear shift towards strengthening research readiness from early on. Universities are adopting multidisciplinary and project-based curricula and offer undergraduate research internships that allow students to work under experienced scientists and engage with real-world problems. Research-intensive institutions are expanding short-term fellowships to give students hands-on experience.

Policy changes

At the policy level, the government has launched various reforms such as the Anusandhan National Research Foundation (NRF) and National Institutional Ranking Framework (NIRF) to prioritise high-quality research and academia-industry collaboration. The One Nation One Subscription (ONOS) initiative aims to widen access to scientific literature, ensuring students from diverse institutions can learn and explore ideas on par with global peers. There is growing emphasis on AI and digital literacy, recognising that modern re-

search requires familiarity with advanced tools and technologies. These developments show a growing recognition that research readiness and scientific temper should be foundational elements, not skills acquired later.

With the world's largest youth population and a rapidly expanding higher education system, sustained investment and long-term policy focus are essential. Equally critical is ensuring the effectiveness of these investments. For example, while ONOS brings a vast collection of subscription journals under one umbrella, the real impact will depend on how easily researchers can discover, navigate, and use the content. Priority should be given to embedding hands-on project opportunities in undergraduate curricula, upgrading laboratories and equipment, expanding updated training models and ensuring equitable access to global research resources. Equally important is cultivating scientific temper, research ethics and interdisciplinary problem solving capability from the earliest stages of higher education.

Once India commits to these reforms, students will enter postgraduate programmes with greater confidence. More importantly, the nation will equip the next generation of researchers not only to participate in global science but to lead it.

The writer is the CEO of Cactus Communications

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INBRIEF



Private hospital launches advanced cancer centre

Iswarya Hospital has inaugurated the Iswarya Cancer Centre at its OMR - Taramani facility, expanding access to advanced cancer diagnosis and treatment. The centre was inaugurated by actor Sathyaraj in the presence of S. Rajasundaram, CEO, and Arun Muthuvel, managing director, along with the hospital's oncology team. The facility brings together comprehensive oncology services under one roof, including surgical oncology, medical oncology, radiation oncology, paediatric oncology, bone marrow transplant, preventive oncology, nuclear medicine, onco-pathology, and palliative care. It is equipped to perform complex cancer surgeries with specialised surgical teams and advanced operation theatres. It also has AI-powered PET-CT imaging and high-precision radiotherapy systems to improve cancer detection, staging, and treatment accuracy.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper. thehindu.com) carries explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (March 9, Monday), the following articles are available:

■ Why did the U.S. Supreme Court reject Trump's tariffs?
newsth.live/trump tariffs ruling

■ Why India's 'leaky pipeline' in research is unlike the rest of the world
newsth.live/stem pipeline

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

A mural celebrates the 'everydayness' of queer life

Conceptualised and designed 'to show queer people as ordinary people', it was commissioned by Avatar Foundation of Arts in collaboration with the office of Thamizhachi Thangapandian, MP

Meenakshy S.
CHENNAI

Just outside Anna University's Kotturpuram gate is a freshly-painted mural that is impossible to miss. On the face of it, the artwork bursts with colours, faces, and some familiar scenes of Chennai. But at its heart, it speaks, perhaps louder than words, about the city's queer community and the 'everydayness' of their lives.

This mural on Tamil queer identity, possibly the first public art installation of its kind in the city, was commissioned by Avatar Foundation of Arts in collaboration with the office of South Chennai MP Thamizhachi Thangapandian. The artwork, made over a span of five days by artists of Aravani Art Project and Anonymous Art Collective, as well as several volunteers from the queer community, was unveiled by the MP on Friday.

"We conceptualised and designed it to show queer people as ordinary people. Queerness is often seen as something entirely different from 'normal' - something that's hypersexual or perverse. For me, this



Wall of pride: The artwork on queer identity outside the Anna University's Kotturpuram gate in Chennai. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

mural is about showing us living normal lives," says Ghana, who works with the Aravani Art Project. "The idea is to take up space, unapologetically, loudly, and proudly. The entire palette is that of a pride flag," she adds.

The artists also wanted to celebrate Chennai's landscape and skyline, which comes through vividly in the mural. It also pays homage to the textiles of Madras, with its intricate checks, says Dee, an artist and volunteer who worked on the project, adding that the piece, while speaking of visibility, has no hint of

'queerbaiting' (i.e., using art to draw members of the community without any meaningful representation).

Joy and pride

Kanchana, a trans woman and an artist with Aravani Art Project, says the mural has been an opportunity for queer people to come together. "Pride [parade] happens once a year, but working with these artists gave me the same joy I feel during Pride... a sense of community," she says, adding: "I've never done queer art like this in Chennai, especially one that has

been fully a queer collaboration."

Ms. Thangapandian said public spaces must reflect the diversity of the people who inhabit them. "This wall is not merely art. It is a statement that equality cannot remain confined to legislation alone but must be visible in our streets and neighbourhoods," she said. "Queer individuals are not on the margins of Tamil society. They are part of its beating heart. When we affirm their dignity openly and unapologetically, we strengthen the very idea of democracy itself," the MP added.



Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin inaugurating the bridge across the Cooum river at Chinna Nalambar in the city on Sunday.

Udhayanidhi opens four-lane bridge over Cooum, new park

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin on Sunday inaugurated a ₹135.62-crore bridge across the Cooum river at Chinna Nalambar.

The four-lane bridge, 245 metres long and 20.7 metres wide, connects Poonamallee High Road and Union Road across the river, according to a press release. The bridge was among the civic projects worth ₹143.21 crore inaugurated by him in the zone.

Mr. Udhayanidhi also laid the foundation stone for a retaining wall and road widening project estimated at ₹12.50 crore.

He inaugurated the Kalaigarn Centenary Park on S.V.S. Nagar First Main Road. Built at a cost of ₹4.88 crore on 16,396 sq.m., the park includes a

pond, walking tracks, a reflexology pathway, green spaces with native trees, an outdoor gym, an open-air theatre, a gazebo, a small bridge, seating areas, a boating deck, lighting and surveillance facilities.

Library inaugurated

He also opened the Kalaigarn Centenary Library and Skill Development Centre on Chinna Porur Hospital Road. Constructed at a cost of ₹2.71 crore under the Namakku Naame scheme, the 6,160 sq.ft. building also has centres to train people in tailoring and other skills, the release said.

Apart from this, Mr. Udhayanidhi also laid the foundation stone for works estimated at ₹12.50 crore, including the construction of a 490-metre retaining wall along the Cooum and the widening of Union Road over a 1.2-km stretch.

Four generations of hosts conduct exclusive quiz to celebrate International Women's Day

Sahana Mira S
CHENNAI

The microphone bounced between the finalist teams, which answered before the question had fully settled in the air, at the Purple Riband Quiz 2026 conducted by the Quiz Foundation of India on Sunday.

This year, the event was an entirely women-only competition to mark International Women's Day.

What made the event also special were the four generations of quiz hosts, who conducted the competition which included questions on a range of topics from the Blind Women's T20 World Cup and instrument virtuosos



Making a change: Participants at the Purple Riband Quiz 2026 on the occasion of International Women's Day. R. RAGU

to K-pop in the preliminary round.

Over 120 registrations

"What is particularly thrilling this year is that about 126 women registered for the quiz competition today [Sunday]. This has never happened before in the history of

Indian quizzing," says Navin Jayakumar, quizmaster and ophthalmologist.

Of the eight teams that reached the finals, the team comprising Aparna Sriram and Savithri Murali came first. G. Bala and Denita Mendez secured the second place, and Latha V. and Jayash-

ree P. finished third. Women can answer questions of any kind, yet quizzing remains a male-dominated field, says 13-year-old quiz host Vanshi Mudaliar. Such competitions may alter that imbalance, she says.

Sharing the panel was India's oldest woman quizmaster Saranya Jayakumar, 85, says she still does not see substantial younger crowd at many open quiz competitions, though she believes the interest for quizzing would pick up.

Signs of change

The packed hall did see signs of that change. Gen Z participants and siblings, Samiha and Surabhi say, "Most quiz

questions revolve around male interests and men. So even as women, we often grow up knowing far more about men's achievements than about women's. When women also set the questions, it becomes more accessible for everyone to participate."

Diverse questions

Quiz host Nirupama V. says the curation had been expansive. "We have tried to keep it as diverse as possible to highlight women's achievements across arts, sports, politics and other fields."

Similarly, quiz host Jayashree Mohanka says that the future of women in quizzing looks decidedly bright.

A lot more work needs to be done for women's progress, says actor Rohini

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A woman doesn't just speak and fight for herself, rather she stands for everyone, actor Rohini said here on Sunday.

While speaking at the Women's Day celebrations organised by the Chennai Press Club, she said, "We have been able to accomplish quite a lot. But there needs to be a lot more work to be done for women. We must understand that and move forward."

T.G. Geetha, assistant director, Directorate General of Goods and Services Tax Intelligence said women look out for each other and stand for each other. She urged journalists to write more about the mental health of women. "Be it depression or



Voicing out: Actor Rohini with other dignitaries at the International Women's Day celebrations held at the Chennai Press Club on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

anxiety, people still consider it a stigma to talk about it. If it was any other disease, people won't hesitate to talk about it. At every given opportunity, write about [how there should be more] awareness [about mental health of women]."

P. Deepa, District Munsif cum Judicial Magis-

trate, Madhavaram, said, "First, we have to cultivate women empowerment in our family. Only then will our society flourish."

'Never give up'

Ramya Kannan, Chief of Bureau (Tamil Nadu), *The Hindu*, said women in the media should never

give up their space and their voices should continue to be heard. "When I visited the press clubs in other cities, I have seen women hold gatherings and would often wonder why it never happens in our city's press club. There were times in the past when women would fear and hesitate to enter the Chennai Press Club. It's an absolute joy to see that this has changed now and we have such celebrations here today," she added.

K. Sundara Bharathi, vice-president, Chennai Press Club also spoke at the event. Prizes were given for top three photographs displayed at an exhibition at the event to three photojournalists and also for winners of the badminton tournament.

20 retired octogenarian professors felicitated

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Retired College Teachers Association (TANRECTA) Chennai chapter held its annual function to felicitate octogenarians in the city on Saturday.

According to a press release, 20 octogenarians were felicitated. Retired joint director of Collegiate Education (Planning and Development) R. Ramanan spoke about the role of teachers and the functioning of TANRECTA.

TANRECTA president V. Swaminathan, TANRECTA Chennai chapter president E.L.Venkatasa-my and secretary C.R. Ravi, among others addressed the gathering.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

Tearful Condolences



02.06.1959 06.03.2026

DR. L. RADHA
(Wife of M. Barathan)

With Heavy hearts, we inform you that my beloved wife Dr. L. Radha passed away on Friday, 06.03.2026, in a road accident. It is with deep regret that her final procession will take place on 09.03.2026, after 9.00 AM at Anna Nagar Velangadu Cemetery.

Son: Sathyakumar. B
Daughter: Sindhu. B
Relatives and friends

Vinoth Versatile, L Block No: 40, 25th Street, Anna Nagar East, Chennai- 600102.

Ph: 9498334356

DEATH

SAD DEMISE



Mrs. M. MEENAMANI,
W/o K.S.MANI IYER,
Demised on 08.03.2026

Final rites
will be performed at
New Avadi Crematorium
at 9.00 am on 09.03.2026.
Krishna Ayyappan

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SIXTEENTH ANNIVERSARY



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DOB: 02.01.1949 - DOD: 09.03.2010
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BIRTHDAY REMEMBRANCE



Dr. CLEMENT J. FELIX
D.O.B. 09.03.1935 - D.O.D. 26.01.2017

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They walk beside us everyday,
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Still loved, still missed and very dear.

Remembered by Dr. Celia White
and loved ones

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CMRL awaits nod from Southern Railway to begin tunnelling below Villivakkam station

TRACK TALES

Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

Chennai Metro Rail Limited (CMRL) has been awaiting the approval from Southern Railway to construct the underground network between Villivakkam Bus Terminus and Villivakkam for the phase 2 project.

CMRL has now taken up this issue with the Project Monitoring Group, created by the Union government to solve bottlenecks in infrastructure projects.

This stretch, a small section of corridor 5 from Madhavaram to Sholinganallur, has been way behind schedule. It has suffered delays since the first tender, floated a few years ago, had to be cancelled as the prospective bidder placed exorbitant quotes. The reissue of the tender and shaft construction went on for a while after that. Now, the tunnel boring machine (TBM) has been lowered and is waiting for launch.

CMRL officials said the work required the approval of the Commissioner of Railway Safety as it includes boring under the Villivakkam Railway station tracks. The CMRL received this clearance in January this year. But, it cannot begin the work without Southern Railway's nod. "We also require another approval from Southern Railway as the speed of trains, which will travel via Villivakkam station, has to be brought down to 20 kmph for a short period, when the TBM drills under the Villivakkam station tracks. We have been waiting for their nod," an official said.

Sources said the CMRL had written to Southern Railway authorities to provide clearance some weeks ago and held discussions as well. While the machine has been lying idle, CMRL sources said they make payments for the machine and manpower running to a few crores without any work happening at the site. "We cannot continue to bear the losses for long," he added.

The TBM has to bore a distance of nearly 600 metres through hard clay and shale to create a tunnel. After the launch, it may take around six months to complete the tunnelling.

This is not the first time that CMRL TBMs will bore beneath railway tracks. Over the past few years, they have done so at a few locations after receiving nod.

Plans to turn junctions across city pedestrian-friendly gather steam

Residents have demanded that the Corporation identify road safety issues as meetings pertaining to a new road safety policy are likely to be held in the coming days; councillors have sought a survey of all major junctions across the city

Aloysius Xavier Lopez
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) plans to make city junctions and locations with rising footfalls more pedestrian-friendly to enhance road safety.

Residents have demanded that the Corporation identify road safety issues and ensure pedestrian-friendly junctions, as meetings pertaining to a new road safety policy are likely to be scheduled in the coming days.

Councillors in GCC wards have demanded a survey of all tri-junctions, four-way junctions, and five-way junctions for implementing pedestrian-friendly crossings.

Egmore Ward 61 councillor Fathima Muzaffer said the safety of pedestrians is compromised at the tri-junctions of Ethiraj College, Pantheon Road, Casa Major Road and Gandhi Irwin Road, particularly for senior citizens and children.

"The foot overbridge is not feasible. We need better alternatives and engineering-driven solutions. Pedestrians cannot cross the road near the Maternity Hospital near the ramp



Right to walk: Councillors in GCC wards have demanded a survey of all tri-junctions, four-way junctions, and five-way junctions for implementing pedestrian-friendly crossings. R. RAVINDRAN

of the overbridge. The GCC should complete the survey of all junctions for pedestrian-friendly crossings," she said.

Pedestrians do not have adequate facilities to cross junctions designed by the GCC, such as the junction where Pantheon Road, Police Commissioner Office Road, and Rukmani Lakshminipathi Salai meet.

Velachery resident S. Kumararaja said: "Pedestrians cannot cross the road near Vijayanagar bus stand, to reach schools located opposite the bus

stand. Senior citizens need more time for crossing the roads and 30 seconds is not adequate. At least one minute is needed in some locations where the distance is 200 feet. We need foot overbridges at some locations while such bridges at places such as Baby Nagar are no longer needed. Let them shift these structures to locations that need such facilities. They should conduct a public consultation before deciding the locations," he said.

Former professor of Urban Engineering at Anna University, K.P. Subramaniam, said: "Inter-institutional coordination is an indispensable requirement. There is no single government department which can be held accountable for road safety. There needs to be an apex body, like a coordination committee under the chairmanship of the Chief Secretary."

Mr. Subramaniam said the current traffic enforcement strategy is in need of a radical change. The present system of visible policing must give way to random policing, successfully adopted by Australian cities to achieve zero accident rate.

An independent and interdisciplinary committee may be made responsible for scientific accident investigation, he said.

A network of footpaths coupled with zero tolerance for encroachments of road spaces and footpaths must be the top priority. Application of technology in traffic management, enforcement and education is another important aspect, he added.

GCC plant to process waste to come up at Keerapakkam

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) will set up a waste-to-energy plant and scientific landfill at Keerapakkam to process 2,400 tonnes of municipal solid waste a day from the Chennai-Tambaram-Avadi cluster.

The State government will provide a construction grant of ₹350 crore for the project. The facility will come up on about 75 acres of land provided by the Tambaram Corporation. Of this, around 50 acres will be earmarked for the scientific landfill.

The plant will have an incineration capacity of 2,400 tonnes of municipal solid waste a day and a rated power generation capacity of 45 MW. The GCC will supply 1,800 tonnes of segregated waste and 800 tonnes of unsegregated waste daily to the facility. A private operator will pre-process the unsegregated waste before it is used for power generation.

The project will also include a pre-processing facility for handling unsegregated waste and infrastructure for the scientific disposal of residual waste. The selected concessionaire will design, finance, build, commission, operate and maintain the facility under a 30-year concession.

Stalin, Palaniswami hail India's win in Men's T20 World Cup final vs NZ

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A "flamboyant triumph", was how Chief Minister M.K. Stalin described Team India winning the ICC Men's T20 World Cup on Sunday night.

In a social media post, Mr. Stalin said: "It was ex-

hilarating to watch Chettan @IamSanjuSamson bat with such authority and composure in the last three matches, delivering when it mattered the most."

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami congratulated Team India on a "majestic victory" over New Zealand, "re-

claiming the crown and once again standing tall as world champions."

"Special appreciation to @IamSanjuSamson for a scintillating performance with the bat, a knock marked by authority, timing, and fearless stroke play," Mr. Palaniswami said in a social media post.

Veteran journalist Ramaswami passes away

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Senior journalist S. Ramaswami, 74, who retired as southern regional bureau head of the *Press Trust of India (PTI)*, passed away at his home in Chennai on Sunday. Born in Thanjavur, he completed his graduation at Pachaiyappa's Col-

lege in the city. He joined *PTI* and worked in the organisation for 30 years. Chief Minister M.K. Stalin in his condolence message, said Ramaswami was close to several former Chief Ministers including M. Karunanidhi. The last rites will be held at 11 a.m. on Monday at the Besant Nagar crematorium.



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4. Period of Completion	: 09 (Nine) Calendar Months.
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6. Bid Security (EMD)	: Rs.4.15 Lacs as per column no.06 of IFB
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Further details can be seen from the e-procurement portal <https://tendersodisha.gov.in>. Any addendum / corrigendum / cancellation of tender can also be seen in the said website only.

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CHENNAI

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TUESDAY, MAR. 10			
RISE	06:20	SET	18:19
RISE	00:00	SET	10:46
WEDNESDAY, MAR. 11			
RISE	06:19	SET	18:19
RISE	00:09	SET	11:35

Chennai Weather

	max	min
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Chennai Airport	35	24
Chennai City	33	24

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38°C The morning will be pleasant. The day will be slightly hot and uneasy. The night also will be pleasant. Dry weather to prevail.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
35°C The weather will be dry. The day will be warm. The night will be pleasant.

THE HINDU

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From Page One

Man dies in police custody in Sivaganga

The statement added that when the police inspector and his team went in search of Akash, he tried to escape from custody. In the process, he sustained serious injuries after falling from a bridge. After a formal arrest intimation was given to his family on March 6, he was admitted to the Government Sivaganga Medical College Hospital. On March 7, the Manamadurai Judicial Magistrate visited the hospital and remanded him in judicial custody till March 18, with a direction to lodge him in the convict ward at the Government Rajaji Hospital (GRH) in Madurai. Hence, he was shifted to the GRH, where he died.

Sources at the GRH said Akash had suffered multiple fractures and the death could have been due to fat embolism, though the exact cause would be known only after a post-mortem.

Henri Tiphagne, advisor to Joint Action Against Custodial Torture and human rights activist, said that with this, the number of custodial deaths reported in Tamil Nadu in recent years had risen to 26. He alleged that police atrocities against the Scheduled Castes and other underprivileged communities continued in the State.

Claiming that Akash died of torture, his family members and relatives refused to accept the body and staged a protest on the Madurai-Rameswaram Highway near the Manamadurai bus stand. They demanded strict action against the police personnel involved in the assault, financial compensation, and a government job for a family member.

Talks held by municipal chairman Mariappan Kennedy failed to convince the protesters. Revenue Divisional Officer Jepi Gracia and Additional Superintendent of Police Francis also attempted to hold negotiations, but the blockade continued, causing a massive traffic jam stretching several kilometres. The victim's father, Rajesh Kannan, and mother, Anandhi, alleged that the police took them to the station, saying that they were looking for their son in connection with a case. "They threatened us, saying, 'If we catch your son, we will kill him'," Mr. Rajesh said. The police released them later, saying that Akash had been arrested, and he sustained a leg fracture. When they saw him, Akash informed them that the police had beaten him. "Under the pretext of investigation, the police took him to a forest area and broke his leg. That is why he died. Had our son committed something wrong, the police could have let the law take its own course. But we cannot accept their beating him to death," Mr. Rajesh added.

INBRIEF



Stalin inaugurates projects in his Kolathur constituency

Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Sunday inaugurated three projects implemented by the Chennai Metropolitan Development Authority at a cost of ₹28.25 crore. These include renovated Murasoli Maran Park, Mudhalvar Padaippagam, and the Kolathur Modern Shopping Complex. He also inaugurated three projects implemented by the Chennai Corporation at a cost of ₹4.15 crore. During a visit to his Kolathur constituency, Mr. Stalin inaugurated upgraded sewage pumping stations built by the Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply and Sewerage Board at a cost of ₹12.48 crore. Minister P.K. Sekarbabu; Chennai Mayor R. Priya; MPs Kalanidhi Veeraswamy and R. Girirajan; MLAs Thayagam Kavi, Joseph Samuel, and A. Vetriazhagan were present at the event.

B. Kolappan

The images of the 100-year-old Krishnammal Jagannathan sitting under a peepal tree at Gandhigram, Dindigul, at the beginning of the documentary, and her standing beside a well without a drop of water at the end, quietly trace the arc of her life's journey.

The movement she spearheaded, along with her late husband Jagannathan, spread like the peepal tree itself, taking root across villages and securing land for the landless. Yet, the dry well reflects another reality – the growing scarcity of idealism-driven movements, both political and non-political, in Tamil Nadu.

A Gandhian who draws

inspiration from Vallalar Ramalinga Adigal – the saint who could not bear even the sight of a withering plant – Ms. Krishnammal turns to prayer with disarming simplicity. Standing beside the parched well in Gandhigram, she seeks divine grace, hoping it will, one day, brim with water again.

"The well remains dry and my mind is in agony. There will come a time when the well will be desilted. Ayya, by your mercy, let the well overflow with water," she prays in a trembling voice in the documentary *Nilam+Needhi=Krishnammal Jagannathan*, directed by Ravi Subramanian.

Two major strands
She represents one of the two major strands that

DMK will meet its downfall for inducting 'traitors' ousted from AIADMK: Palaniswami

AIADMK recognises the individuals who work for it, unlike the DMK that prioritises the CM's family; *Magalir Urimai Thittam* was implemented only after pressure from AIADMK, he says

The Hindu Bureau

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami on Sunday said the ruling DMK would face the consequences for associating with "traitors" expelled from the AIADMK, and that their inclusion would eventually lead to the DMK's downfall.

Addressing a public meeting at Perundurai in Erode district as part of his State-wide election tour, Mr. Palaniswami said former AIADMK leader O. Panneerselvam had attempted to weaken the party after the death of former Chief Minister Jayalalithaa.

Mr. Panneerselvam had forgotten how the party and its leadership had given him the opportunity to serve as the Chief Minister (thrice), he said.

Referring to former Minister V. Senthilbalaji, Mr. Palaniswami alleged that protecting himself was his priority and that the party came second to his personal interests.

'AIADMK is strong'
Responding to Chief Minister M.K. Stalin's remark that the BJP would destroy the AIADMK, Mr. Palaniswami said the party was strong and no force could weaken it.

The AIADMK was a party that recognised the individuals who worked for it



AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami addressing a public meeting at Perundurai in Erode district as part of his State-wide tour on Sunday. M. GOVARTHAN

and gave them posts accordingly. In contrast, in the DMK, only members of the Chief Minister's family were given positions of power, he added.

Addressing a public meeting in the Bhavani Assembly constituency later in the evening, Mr. Palaniswami alleged that the ₹1,000 monthly assistance under the *Kalaigarn Magalir Urimai Thittam* was implemented only after pressure from the AIADMK. It was introduced 28 months after the DMK assumed office, he added.

According to him, several infrastructure projects initiated during the AIADMK regime were stalled by the DMK government.

He alleged that the ₹950-crore Bhavani-Thopur four-lane road project

had not progressed under the present government.

Subsidy for women
At a meeting in Salem, Mr. Palaniswami said a subsidy of ₹25,000 will be given to five lakh women for buying two-wheelers when the party returns to power in Tamil Nadu. He celebrated International Women's Day with the AIADMK women's wing functionaries by cutting a cake.

Former Chief Ministers M.G. Ramachandran and Jayalalithaa had implemented several schemes for women. When the AIADMK comes to power, women family heads will get ₹2,000 every month, Mr. Palaniswami said.

Jayalalithaa had implemented the Amma Two-Wheeler Scheme for women. However, it was dis-

continued after the DMK came to power, he said.

Responding to a question on Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam president Vijay's announcements for women, Mr. Palaniswami said the TVK leader made the announcements for the election just like a political party would release its election manifesto.

When asked whether Mr. Vijay's announcements were similar to the promises made by the AIADMK, Mr. Palaniswami said the question should be posed to Mr. Vijay.

"Every party releases its election promises. I announced that the *Magalir Urimai Thogai* will be increased to ₹2,000 from ₹1,000. Mr. Stalin announced the same. So he too should be asked this question," he added.

Any disrespect to President is unacceptable: EPS on Bengal government's 'protocol failure'

The Hindu Bureau

After President Droupadi Murmu expressed disappointment with the West Bengal government over the conduct of an event in that State, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami said on Sunday that any such disrespect was deeply regrettable and unacceptable.

The President on Saturday had condemned the State government for changing the venue of the International Santal Conference in Darjeeling district and not adhering to the de-

sired protocol to receive her at the event.

In a social media post, Mr. Palaniswami said it was "deeply saddening that our Hon'ble President had to publicly express anguish over such an incident". He added, "Constitutional offices are not mere ceremonial symbols – they embody the dignity of our Republic."

Without naming anyone, he said, "Those entrusted with governance carry the responsibility of ensuring that administrative conduct always reflects due respect to the nation's highest office."

AMMK founder T.T.V. Dhinakaran too condemned the incident and said West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee should tender an apology to the tribal communities.

Mr. Dhinakaran said the President, "who is beyond politics", had been insulted for political reasons.

The protocol of either the Chief Minister or a Minister welcoming the President on arrival was violated, Mr. Dhinakaran said, adding that the change of the venue for the event at the eleventh hour amounted to insulting the President.

Congress will lead secular alliance, which includes DMK, in Puducherry: TNCC chief

The Hindu Bureau

Tamil Nadu Congress Committee (TNCC) president K. Selvaperunthagai on Sunday said the Congress party would lead the alliance in Puducherry just as "the DMK leads the alliance in Tamil Nadu".

Addressing the media at the TNCC headquarters in Chennai, he said the Congress would lead the secular alliance, which includes the DMK, in Puducherry.

Mr. Selvaperunthagai and other leaders were part of a discussion with AICC observer Mukul Was-

T.N. forms panel to frame rules to ban hostile dog breeds

S. Vijay Kumar

The Tamil Nadu government has constituted an expert committee to frame draft "Pet and Community Dog Bye-laws" to regulate or ban aggressive and dangerous dog breeds in the interest of public safety.

Acting on proposals from the Department of Animal Husbandry and Veterinary Services and the Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC), the State government issued orders last week forming the committee, which has been asked to submit its recommendations at the earliest.

The move follows the decision of a committee set up by the Union government that identified certain dog breeds as ferocious and dangerous to human life. The committee recommended that such breeds, including cross-breeds, be prohibited for import, breeding, and sale as pets.

In a proposal to the State government, the GCC Commissioner noted that certain dog breeds had been identified as ferocious and aggressive, and caused harm to the public. He requested the government to issue orders or guidelines banning the possession of such breeds as pets and to stop the renewal of licences for these categories of dogs within the Corporation's jurisdiction.

The Director of Animal Husbandry and Veterinary Services recommended the formation of an expert committee to study the issue and guide the govern-

A panel set up by the Centre recommended banning the import, breeding, and sale of aggressive breeds

ment in drafting the proposed bye-laws. The committee may examine ways to regulate or ban aggressive and dangerous dog breeds to ensure the safety of the public, society, and other living beings, he said.

The panel could also review existing regulations governing such breeds and draft Standard Operating Procedures for their ownership, handling, and enforcement.

The expert committee will be headed by the Director of Municipal Administration as its chairperson. The Chief Executive Officer of the Tamil Nadu Animal Welfare Board will serve as the Member-Secretary and Convenor, along with six other members.

Centre's decision
In a communication to States in March 2024, the Ministry of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry, and Dairying urged local bodies not to issue licences or permits for the sale, breeding or possession of certain ferocious dog breeds, recommending that such breeds be banned.

The Union government has also notified the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (Dog Breeding and Marketing) Rules, 2017, and the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (Pet Shop) Rules, 2018.



K. Selvaperunthagai

and the formation of booth and village committees. He has also spoken to important leaders in Tamil Nadu. Based on this, he has guided us on how we can contribute to our alliance partners in all 234 Assembly constituencies," Mr. Chodankar said.

When asked if the Congress is happy with the number of seats allotted to it, Mr. Wasnik said, "Prior to the decision on seat-sharing, various aspects were taken into consideration. At the end of the day, we have made a decision, and other parties in the alliance have accepted it."

nik and AICC in-charge for Tamil Nadu and Puducherry Girish Chodankar.

"As far as Tamil Nadu is concerned, he [Mr. Wasnik] has reviewed the preparations in the Assembly segments - our contributions to the SIR [Special Intensive Revision] process,

Krishnammal Jagannathan: a symbol of Gandhian model of empowerment



A scene from the documentary *Nilam+Needhi=Krishnammal Jagannathan*, where the 100-year-old Gandhian is seen sitting under a peepal tree at Gandhigram in Dindigul.

buted to the poor – entered the composite Thanjavur district to organise landless peasants in the af-

termath of the 1968 Keezhenmani massacre, in which 44 Dalits, including children, were burnt alive.

Reflecting on her life-long struggle, Ms. Balabharathi holds Ms. Krishnammal's hand and tells her:

"Your life itself is history. Born in an ordinary family and subjected to the oppression of caste, you stood firm in your struggle to secure land for people on the margins of society. In a way, you have done what we too set out to do."

Early encounter

Life was anything but easy. Even at The American College in Madurai, where she studied, fellow students kept their distance from her because of her caste. Her encounter with Soundaram Ramachandran – founder of the Gandhigram Rural Institute, which later became a deemed university – set Ms. Krishnammal firmly on the Gandhian path.

"I was asked by Soundaram Amma to take care of Gandhi during his three-

day stay in Madurai," recalls Ms. Krishnammal, remembering the moment that shaped the course of her life.

She also acknowledges how her husband Jagannathan, born into a wealthy family, stood firmly by her side and went on to found Land for Tillers' Freedom (LAF TI). Together, they worked to transform the lives of poor and landless peasants.

She also records the support extended by former Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi, who met her and facilitated the registration of identified lands in the names of landless farmers.

"No conflict with landlords; no compromise with anyone. Our only aim should be to liberate women from the hands of landlords," she says.



The need to recognise ‘volunteer’ care work

The Union Budget 2026-27 proposes to build a ‘strong care ecosystem’ by training 1.5 lakh multiskilled caregivers in geriatric, core care and allied skills through programmes aligned with the National Skills Qualification Framework (NSQF). As India’s care needs expand, such a move is both timely and necessary.

However, the Budget reveals a deeper paradox; even as the state prepares to train a new cadre of certified care professionals, it makes little mention of the five million plus women who already run India’s health, nutrition and childcare systems. Our Accredited Social Health Activists (ASHAs), Anganwadi workers and helpers, and mid-day meal workers continue to deliver essential public services every day, yet remain classified as ‘volunteers’, excluded from the very ecosystem the state now seems determined to strengthen.

A shadow labour force
From the Anganwadi worker ensuring a child is fed to the ASHA worker tracking a pregnancy in a remote village, these women constitute the backbone of India’s welfare architecture. Their work is essential, continuous and indispensable to the state, yet they labour in a deeply precarious space, earning meagre monthly honorariums, without formal contracts, paid leaves or maternity benefits. What little support they receive come from small and fragmented responses by individual States such as honorarium hikes (which vary from State to State) and gratuity benefits, or coverage under national schemes such as Ayushman Bharat and Pradhan Mantri Shram Yogi Maandhan. But these piecemeal measures do little to address the contradiction that lies at the core of India’s care economy – that the state relies on a vast, feminised shadow labour force of women to deliver essential public services but classifies them as ‘honorary workers’ to limit



Renjini Rajagopalan
Lawyer and research lead at the Centre for Gender Analysis, JustJobs Network (JJN)

India’s so-called ‘volunteer’ care workers are in reality the permanent pillars of our welfare state

protections typically associated with formal employment.

A gendered form of work
This contradiction is rooted in deeper structural norms surrounding care. The ‘care penalty’ in India is not just a sociological concept, it is a statistical reality. Insights from the 2024 Time Use Survey highlighted in the Economic Survey 2025-26 reinforce Indian women’s role as primary caregivers, with 41% of females aged 15-59 spending 140 minutes daily on household caregiving, compared to just 21.4% of males at 74 minutes.

This pattern mirrors India’s welfare architecture. By outsourcing its care responsibilities to women labelled as ‘volunteers’, the state draws on long-standing social norms that view care work as an extension of a woman’s domestic duty rather than skilled labour deserving fair compensation. Since care is seen as ‘natural’ to women, it is rendered cheap and informal. This creates a vicious cycle – the less care work is recognised as skilled, the less compulsion there is to pay for it, trapping a predominantly female workforce in insecure employment. Against this background, the recent Budget’s emphasis on investing in a new cohort of care workers exposes the absence of clear avenues to integrate its existing workforce; these workers already perform complex, multi-skilled tasks that demand emotional labour, field coordination, and deep knowledge of community dynamics. So why is the state not looking to upgrade and secure the livelihoods of those who already perform such critical work?

India’s so-called ‘volunteer’ care workers are in reality the permanent pillars of our welfare state. The country cannot realise its ambitions to be a global powerhouse for health while the women who sustain such systems

remain underpaid, unprotected and largely invisible. But reimagining India’s care economy requires both financial investment and a cultural shift.

Reimagining the care economy
To begin with, India must move beyond the ‘volunteer’ label. In the Supreme Court’s 2025 ruling in *Dharam Singh & Anr. vs State of U.P. & Anr.*, the Court upheld that work which is recurrent and central to an institution’s functioning cannot be treated as temporary indefinitely. For India’s cadre of ‘volunteer’ care workers who perform duties that are indispensable and continuous in nature to the state, this judgment offers a strong basis to demand that their honorary roles be converted into permanent posts.

Combined with the renewed Budgetary focus on skilling, this creates an opportune moment to revisit employment norms governing India’s existing care workforce, and nudge the state towards the creation of clear transition

frameworks that help move these workers from honorariums to fair wages and formal contracts. Perhaps the first step could be to extend the proposed NSQF-aligned programmes to ASHA and Anganwadi workers as well.

For years, these workers have mobilised across the country to demand dignity and recognition of their work. It is now past time that the state responds by fulfilling the final two commitments – Reward and Represent – of the International Labour Organisation’s 5R Framework for Decent Care Work. Our care workers who perform tirelessly need to be properly compensated and given a genuine voice in employment and policy decisions: in short, a real seat at the table.

This is the sixth and final article in a curated selection published on the Editorial and Opinion pages, on March 6 and 7, marking International Women’s Day.



A successful but battered alliance

The DMK-Congress seat sharing agreement in Tamil Nadu has come at a cost

STATE OF PLAY

B. Kolappan
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After days of hard bargaining, and at times pushing the alliance to the brink of collapse, the Congress in Tamil Nadu has finally sealed a seat-sharing pact with the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) for the forthcoming Assembly elections. The Congress, which was allotted 25 seats and won 18 in the 2021 Assembly polls, has managed to secure three additional seats and a Rajya Sabha berth from the DMK as part of the agreement.

An unrelenting Congress
The Congress’s hardened stance surprised even leaders in the rival camp, particularly because the party has been a constituent of the DMK-led alliance for nearly 22 years, barring a brief separation in 2014. The DMK-Congress combine in Tamil Nadu is often cited as a model alliance against the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-led combine at the Centre.

The Congress high command, however, appeared to be quietly preparing for an experiment in Tamil Nadu despite the much-publicised bonhomie between Chief Minister M.K. Stalin and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, who often address each other as “brother.” Throughout the roller-coaster negotiations, Mr. Gandhi kept himself away from directly dealing with Mr. Stalin. The continuation of the alliance was eventually ensured by the intervention of former Union Minister and senior Congress leader P. Chidambaram, who was asked by Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Sonia Gandhi to negotiate for the party.

The Congress appears to be readying itself for an experiment after the emergence of actor Vijay’s Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam (TVK). For decades, Tamil Nadu politics has been dominated by two Dravidian parties – the DMK and the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) – despite challenges from sub-regional forces such as the Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK), the Tamil nationalist outfit Naam Tamizhar Katchi (NTK), and the promise once shown by actor Vijayakanth’s Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK).

Actor Vijay, however, has succeeded in creating the perception that he represents a possible alternative. A section of leaders within the Congress favoured exploring an alliance with the TVK, believing it could allow the party to contest a larger number of seats. Yet such a move would have once again underlined the Congress’s continuing dependence on regional allies rather than its own organisational strength – effectively piggy-backing on another party instead of the DMK.

However, the very idea that the Congress was thinking of joining hands with the TVK surprised many observers, as it would have led to far-reaching consequences for Indian politics in general. Such a realignment would have been precisely the opportunity the BJP might have been waiting

for, as it could have dealt a severe blow to the INDIA bloc by weakening one of its most significant pillars in the south.

The BJP, fully aware that the DMK has, in recent years, emerged as one of its strongest ideological opponents, is unlikely to soften its stance. For the Congress, losing the DMK’s backing in Parliament would have made it considerably more vulnerable at the national level, both politically and numerically – an opportunity the BJP would have been keen to exploit.

DMK’s dilemma
The sealing of the pact has, for now, saved the alliance but left deep scars. The Congress may have succeeded in persuading the DMK to part with a few additional seats, but it has also paved the way for other allies in the DMK-led front to demand more. Already overcrowded with nearly 20 political parties and fringe groups, the DMK alliance is under enormous pressure to accommodate competing demands.

Anticipating the possibility of a breakdown in talks with the Congress, the DMK had already roped in several parties, including the DMDK. It had also inducted former AIADMK Chief Minister O. Panneerselvam into the ruling party.

The DMK’s next challenge will be identifying seats for its allies, as their interests overlap in many constituencies. At the same time, the party is keen to contest as many seats as possible to avoid a repeat of the situation in 2006, when M. Karunanidhi had to form a government with outside support from its allies, particularly the Congress and the PMK. The DMK leadership is well aware that if it falls short of a majority again, the Congress will not hesitate to demand its pound of flesh.

How duty cuts in cancer drugs will ease burden for patients

While private hospitals charge more than public facilities for cancer treatment, the relative financial burden is higher in the government sector

DATA POINT

Debasree Purkayastha

The most expensive disease just got a little more affordable to treat in India. Cancer treatment costs are three times higher than the hospitalisation expenditure for any average ailment in the country. Its medicines itself form the single largest component of expenditure in public hospitals – especially in rural areas. The full exemption of basic customs duty proposed on 17 cancer-related drugs and medicines in the Budget, acts as a welcome balm for the stinging costs of life-saving care.

With India recording a 26.4% rise in cancer incidence between 1990 and 2023 – among the highest increases globally – the cost of treating the disease has become a severe burden. As the disease spreads, the financial strain on patients is deepening faster than the health system’s ability to absorb it.

According to the 2017-18 National Sample Survey (NSS) on health, the average cost for a typical hospital stay was ₹20,135, while cancer patients spent over ₹61,000 per visit. These figures represent national averages, including at both public and private healthcare facilities (**Chart 1**).

When the data is disaggregated by facility type, a worrying trend emerges. While it is well-documented that private hospitals charge over four times more than public facilities for cancer treatment, the relative financial burden is actually higher in the government sector. In private hospitals, the average cost of cancer care (₹93,305) was roughly three times that of a typical hospitalisation (₹31,845) in 2017-18. In contrast, a cancer stay in a public hospital (₹22,520) costs about five times as much as a standard admission (₹4,452). This higher ‘cost multiplier’ in the public sector suggests that cancer care places a disproportionately heavy strain on the

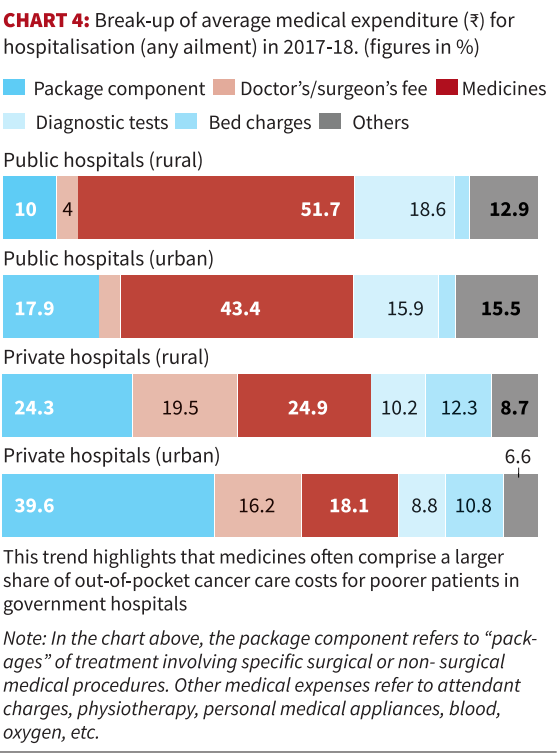
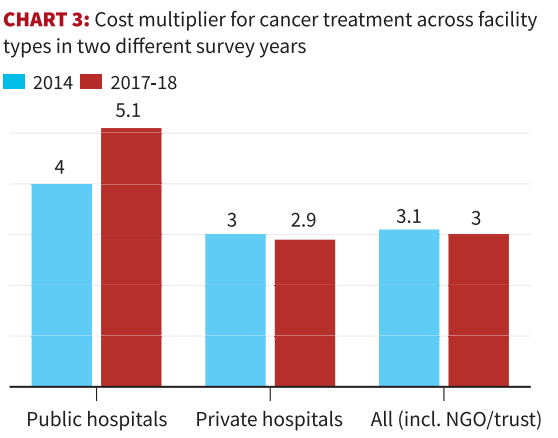
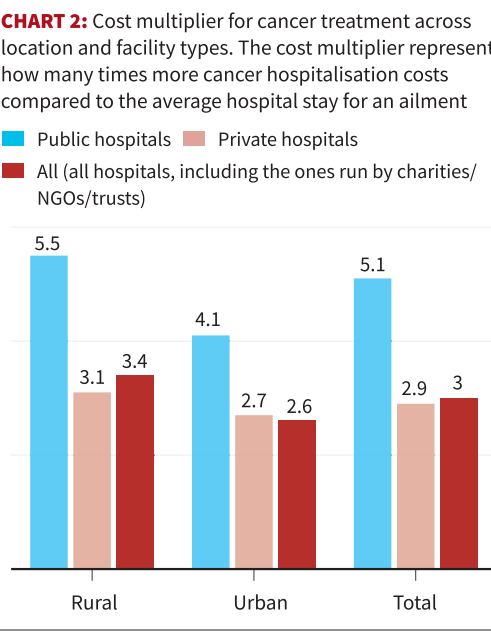
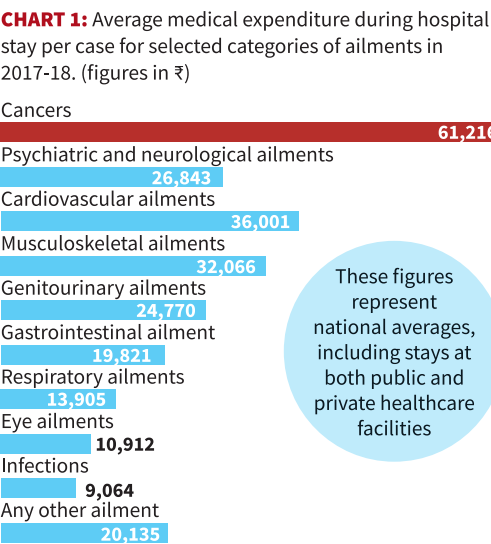
resources of the poor. The financial strain is even more pronounced when the data is disaggregated by location. In rural public hospitals, the cost multiplier for cancer treatment climbs to 5.5x, compared to 4.1x in urban public facilities. Notably, this rural-urban disparity is far less significant in the private sector, where the relative cost burden remains more consistent regardless of location (**Chart 2**).

Widening gap
It is also significant that this gap in public hospitals was not nearly as wide, just a few years earlier, in 2014. According to the 2014 NSS on health, the average cost of cancer care in private hospitals (₹78,050) was roughly three times that of a typical hospitalisation (₹25,850). This indicates that the cost multiplier for private hospitals remained consistent in the four years leading up to the latest 2017-18 data. In contrast, in 2014, a cancer stay in a public hospital (₹24,526) costs about four times as much as a standard admission (₹6,120). It is important to note that this cost multiplier for public hospitals has increased by a full point – climbing from 4 in 2014 to 5 in the 2017-18 figures (**Chart 3**).

A look at hospitalisation costs shows that medicines form the single largest component of medical expenditure across both public and private hospitals, in rural as well as urban India. This is especially true in public hospitals, where doctor and surgeon fees are negligible; here, spending on medicines accounts for approximately 40% to 50% of the total expense. Even in private hospitals – where doctor fees and package costs are substantial – the share of expenditure on medicines still represents around 20% to 25% of the bill (**Chart 4**). This trend highlights that medicines comprise a larger share of out-of-pocket cancer care costs for poorer patients in government hospitals, making the recent duty reduction a key intervention.

Cutting costs

The data for the charts were sourced from the National Sample Survey (NSS) Round 71 for 2014 and Round 75 for 2017-18, released by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO MARCH 9, 1976

Japanese economic team to visit Pak.

Tokyo, March 8: The Foreign Ministry announced here to-day that a powerful Japanese economic commission, composed of some of the topmost industrial leaders, would be going to Pakistan for an eight-day visit to promote closer relations between the two countries.

The 28 man mission to be headed by Mr. Hiroki Imazato, Board Chairman of Nippon Seiko Company Ltd., will include officials from the Foreign Ministry, the Finance Ministry, the Ministry of International Trade and Industry and the Architecture and Forestry Ministry. Most of Japan’s top industrial and trading houses will be represented in the mission.

During their stay in Pakistan the members of the mission will exchange views with Government and business leaders of that country on ways to expand trade and technical exchanges and other economic co-operation.

Although the publicly announced objective of the mission is to promote closer economic relations, its visit to Pakistan at this juncture assumes greater significance in the light of several recent developments, indicating a new Japanese anxiety to strengthen relations with Pakistan for good reasons. Till recently Japan’s relations with Pakistan were correct and formal but there was no particular inclination on the part of Tokyo to go much beyond this.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO MARCH 9, 1926

Broadcasting musical compositions

London, March 8: The Music Publishers Association of London have decided to send an ultimatum to the British Broadcasting Company stating that, unless the Company agree to royalties on popular music, which has been the subject of a long discussion, they will withdraw permission to broadcast their copyright numbers immediately. It is stated that, this will mean the immediate exclusion of all dance music from wireless programme. The publishers say they are not asking a higher fee and have even agreed to accept lower fees than last year, but could not afford to agree to the Company’s proposed rates. It is declared that the Broadcasting Company have reduced the life of popular songs to a few weeks.

‘Insult’ to President: BJP slams Mamata, seeks her resignation

CM says responsibility for mismanagement, if any, of event attended by the President lay with its private organisers and the Airports Authority of India, which had provided the venue; BJP MPs from the State say Trinamool chief should resign

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

The controversy over breach of protocol and change of venue of an event during President Droupadi Murmu's visit to Darjeeling on Saturday continued to rage in West Bengal's political circles on Sunday, with the Bharatiya Janata Party leadership demanding the resignation of Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee over the developments.

The insult to President Murmu was an insult to tribals of the State, BJP MPs from West Bengal representing Scheduled Tribe (ST) communities said.

“The Chief Minister should resign immediately. Seeking an apology will not work. In the interest of the tribal community, she must resign,” Khagen Murmu, BJP MP from the Malda Uttar Lok Sabha constituency, said at a press conference in Kolkata.

President Droupadi Murmu on Saturday expressed her anguish against the West Bengal government for changing the venue of the International Santhal Conference in Darjeeling district, and not adhering to the desired pro-



Voicing dissent: West Bengal Chief Minister and Trinamool Congress Mamata Banerjee during a protest in Kolkata on Sunday against the increase in LPG cylinder price. ANI

to receive her at the event. The Governor, Chief Minister or any West Bengal Minister were not present to receive the President in Darjeeling on Saturday.

Responding to the charges made against her, Ms. Banerjee on Sunday asserted there had been no breach of protocol at Ms. Murmu's event on Saturday. The responsibility for mismanagement at the function, if any, lay with its private organisers and the Airports Authority of In-

dia, which had provided the venue, the Chief Minister said.

Whereas on Saturday the Trinamool Congress chairperson had targeted the President, urging her “not to play politics at the advice of the BJP”, on Sunday she said that her government had “full respect for the Chair of the President, and the Constitution”.

CM's dharna

Ms. Banerjee, who has been sitting on a dharna in

Kolkata since Friday against the deletion of electors' names in the special intensive revision (SIR) in the State, accused Mr. Modi of insulting the President. She also held protest against the LPG price hike.

The West Bengal CM made public a photograph of Mr. Modi remaining seated at an event with veteran BJP leader L.K. Advani, with President Murmu standing next to them.

“The picture shows that the Prime Minister is seated when the President is

standing. We never do that. It is the BJP which carries the culture of insulting the President, not us,” Ms. Banerjee said, displaying the photograph as “evidence of the insult”.

With the Assembly election in West Bengal due in the next two months, breach of protocol relating to the President of India, who hails from a tribal community, has assumed political proportions.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who had described it as “shameful and unprecedented” on Saturday, on Sunday said that the Trinamool Congress had not only boycotted an important event of the tribal community but also boycotted the President.

“The President comes from the Adivasi community. She is concerned about the development of the Adivasi Santhal community. The Trinamool Congress has subjected the event to mismanagement. This is not only an insult to the President, but also an insult to the spirit of the Constitution as well as the rich traditions of democracy in our country,” Mr. Modi said while participating in an event at the national capital.

Darjeeling district officials had raised alarm over lack of arrangements at venue

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Amid outrage over alleged denial of a welcome with proper protocol to President Droupadi Murmu in Darjeeling on Saturday, communication from district officials to their superiors point out that they had raised an alarm over the arrangements at the International Santhal Conference.

The Sub-Divisional Officer of Siliguri on March 4 wrote to the District Magistrate, Darjeeling that preparatory work at the venue had not yet been started by the organiser, despite the fact that only two days remained for the programme.

“In view of the importance and sensitivity of the programme, particularly due to the presence of the Hon'ble President of India, adequate preparation of the venue and related infrastructure is of utmost necessity. However, it has been observed today during inspection that preparatory work at the venue has not yet been started by the organiser, despite the fact that only two days remain before the scheduled programme,” the SDO, Siliguri wrote to the Darjeeling District Magistrate.

A Minister-in-waiting should have received the President in absence of CM and Governor: officials

The SDO urged the DM to issue directions to the organiser so that immediate steps may be taken to ensure proper preparation well before the scheduled date of the programme.

‘Sought review’

The very same day on March 4, the District Magistrate wrote to the Officer on Special Duty and Under-Secretary to the Government of West Bengal, seeking a review with the organiser about the preparations and arrangements. “In case it appears that they are not in a position to put up a proper programme, then the viability of holding the programme may be reviewed,” the DM wrote. The District Magistrate had suggested that “this may kindly be taken up with the Office of Hon'ble President of India”.

The OSD had forwarded the communication to the Protocol and Tour Officer,

President's Secretariat, and Rashtrapati Bhavan.

On Sunday, Union Home Secretary Govind

Mohan sought a report from West Bengal Chief Secretary Nandini Chakravorty over violation of the “Blue Book” protocols during President Murmu's visit.

Officials who have been involved with the arrangements during events where the President has been present said that the protocols and rules as per the “Blue Book” have to be adhered to during such visits.

“There is a concept of a Minister-in-waiting who should be present to welcome the President if the Chief Minister is unavailable. Usually it is a senior Minister in the State's Council of Ministers, but in this case neither the Governor [who had resigned] nor the Chief Minister [who was on dharna in Kolkata] nor any Minister-in-waiting was present to welcome the President,” the official said.

The Mayor of Siliguri, Gautam Deb, who was present at the event to receive the President, cannot be accorded the status of a Minister-in-waiting as per the protocol laid in the “Blue Book”.

Officials said that the rules laid in the “Blue Book” cannot be changed as per convenience of the State government.

Resignation was a conscious decision: Bengal ex-Governor

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

C.V. Ananda Bose, who resigned as Governor of West Bengal on March 5, said on Sunday that his resignation was a “conscious decision”.

Denying suggestions that his exit was sudden and abrupt, the former West Bengal Governor said that he had been given enough opportunity to decide for himself what the right time to quit should be. “I have taken a conscious decision to resign. The reasons for this will remain confidential till the right time comes,” he told presspersons here.

“I knew the day I assumed the office that a time would come when I

would have to vacate it,” Mr. Bose said. “I spent over 1,200 days in the office. That's equivalent to scoring 12 centuries on the cricket field. The rules of the game include knowing when it ends,” Mr. Bose said.

Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee has expressed concern over the sudden exit of Mr. Bose ahead of the Assembly election in the State. Mr. Bose had been forced to quit by the Union Home Ministry, she alleged. Mr. Bose's resignation appears sudden as he became a voter in West Bengal on February 27.

Calling himself a “proud voter of Bengal”, Mr. Bose said he would return to cast his vote during the election.

Jaishankar to make statement in Parliament on conflict in West Asia

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar will make a statement in the Lok Sabha on Monday, after days of criticism from Opposition parties and a number of former Indian diplomats over the government's “silence” on the conflict in West Asia.

A notice for the statement on “The situation in West Asia” was added to the list of business for the Lower House of Parliament on Sunday evening.

He is expected to make the statement shortly before the Lok Sabha takes up the Opposition's resolution against Speaker Om Birla.

Over the past week, Opposition parties have censured the government for



S. Jaishankar

not criticising the U.S.-Israeli attacks on Iran, including a school in which more than 150, mostly schoolgirls, were killed, and targeting of other civilian infrastructure, although it has condemned Iran's attacks on Gulf countries. The Congress questioned the timing of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Israel on February

25-26, just before the war began. On Sunday, Congress leader and former External Affairs Minister Salman Khurshid said this was not the time for “politics”, but urged the government to make a more vocal appeal to the U.S., Israel, and Iran to end the war.

“There was a time when India's voice echoed, mattered, and was heard sincerely. This mass destruction must be stopped, and peace must be restored,” he said, after signing the condolence book at the Iranian Embassy.

Last week, the Opposition parties as well as several former Indian diplomats slammed the government for not raising with the U.S. its sinking of the Iranian Ship *IRIS Dena*, killing dozens of Iranian sailors returning from na-

val exercises with India, especially as India has pitched its naval power as the “net security provider” in the Indian Ocean Region.

At the Raisina Dialogue, Mr. Jaishankar said that the “reality” of the Indian Ocean was that it was not “limited to only the countries of the Indian Ocean”, dismissing the questions on the issue as “non-serious”.

Since U.S.-Israeli strikes on Tehran on February 28, which killed Iran's Supreme Leader Khamenei with several members of his family and government, the Ministry of External Affairs has issued three statements calling for “dialogue and diplomacy” and expressing increasing levels of concern over the escalation of violence.

Motion to remove Speaker sets stage for a stormy session

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The second part of the Budget Session of Parliament is set to resume from Monday and is expected to be stormy, with the first item on the agenda being the debate over the Motion of Removal admitted against Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla.

The resolution, listed against Congress MPs Mohammad Jawed, K. Suresh and Mallu Ravi, has been signed by 118 Opposition members.

Speaker Birla will not be presiding over the proceedings; instead, in the absence of a Deputy Speaker, the senior-most MP in the presiding officers committee, likely Bharatiya Janata Party MP Jagdambika Pal, may preside over the debate. Speaker Birla is permitted under the rules to be present and may be allotted a seat among the Cabinet Ministers.

Motions seeking the removal of Lok Sabha Speakers are not very common but are not unprecedented, with even the first Speaker of the Lok Sabha, G.V. Mavalankar, being subject to it in 1954, followed by Hukum Singh in 1966. The last such instance was in 1987, against then Speaker Balram Jakhar.

In each of these cases, the motion failed, and the Speaker remained in office. It is expected that in

Numbers show that the Opposition motion to remove Om Birla will be defeated

this case too, Mr. Birla will sail through as the ruling National Democratic Alliance has a comfortable strength of about 335 seats out of a strength of 543, with the Opposition Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) with 230 MPs falling short of the number to remove the Speaker under Article 94(c) of the Constitution. Senior Ministers of the NDA government are expected to speak during the debate, say government floor managers.

The wording of the resolution claims that the Speaker has “ceased to maintain an impartial attitude necessary to command the confidence of all sections of the House”. It alleges that he has disregarded the rights of members while “openly espousing the version of the ruling party on controversial matters”.

The Opposition, which will be meeting on Monday morning for a strategy session at the office of the Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha, Mallikarjun Kharge, is hoping to press its point, at least in public discourse, as the numbers show that the motion will be defeated.

Nitish's son Nishant joins JD(U), says he will take forward father's work

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

Nishant Kumar, son of Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, on Sunday, officially joined the ruling Janata Dal(U) at the party headquarters in Patna.

JD(U) working president Sanjay Kumar Jha inducted Mr. Nishant into the party.

Senior party leaders, including Rajeev Ranjan Singh, alias Lalan Singh, State party president Umesh Singh Kushwaha, Bijendra Yadav, Zama Khan, and Vijay Kumar Choudhury were present.

Mr. Nitish Kumar, however, was absent. He was reviewing work at the Bihar and Patna museums in the State capital at the time, sources said. Mr. Nishant met him after he joined the party.

“I will try to take for-



New innings: Nishant Kumar, son of Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, joins the Janata Dal(U) in Patna on Sunday. ANI

ward what my papa [Mr. Nitish] has done for the people of Bihar...will try to take it [developmental works] to the people of Bihar,” Mr. Nishant, 50, said at the event.

“We all are proud of my father,” he said.

“Today, I have come

here to join the JD(U) and it was my father's personal decision, which I have accepted...we will all work under the direction of my father,” he said.

“I will try to take the works done by my father for the development of Bihar forward,” he said.

A large number of JD(U) supporters and workers gathered outside the party headquarters at Bir Chand Patel Path here to welcome Mr. Nishant. Slogans of “When Nishant Kumar is around, we are reassured” were heard. Drums, fleets of vehicles, and elephants, camels, and horses added to the celebratory mood.

“Now, we want to see him [Mr. Nishant] as Chief Minister of Bihar,” the crowd was heard saying.

Mr. Nishant was born on July 20, 1975, and like his father, is an engineer by education. His schooling was in Patna, and he later completed his engineering degree from the Birla Institute of Technology, Mesra, Ranchi.

Speculation is rife that Mr. Nishant will be made a Deputy Chief Minister in the new government.

CEC arrives in Bengal, to hold meetings on poll preparedness

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar on Sunday arrived in Kolkata on a three-day visit to poll-bound West Bengal.

Mr. Kumar will lead the full bench of the Election Commission to review the preparations for the Assembly election likely within the next two months.

The CEC will hold meetings with officials of West Bengal government and representatives of political parties over the next few days.

According to EC sources, Mr. Kumar will hold a meeting with political parties from 10 a.m. on Monday. Representatives of eight recognised parties will meet the CEC and the full bench. About 15 minutes have been allotted for delegations of each political party.

Later in the day, the EC officials will hold a meeting with officials of the West Bengal government, including senior police officials, Superintendents of Police and District Magistrates. It will hold a press conference on Tuesday.

The EC on February 28 had published the State's electoral rolls of about 7.04 crore voters after a four-month process of special intensive revision (SIR). The list contains about 60 lakh voters whose right to vote remains under judicial adjudication.

The crucial question remains whether the names of all the 60 lakh electors will be cleared before the announcement of the poll dates.

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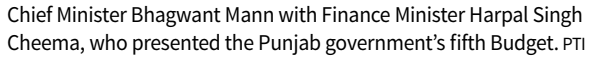
Prime Minister Narendra Modi conveyed greetings to women on the occasion of International Women's Day, and said the achievements of India's 'Nari Shakti' are a source of pride. He said that the empowerment of women is at the core of his government's various schemes and initiatives and it remains committed to creating opportunities that enable every woman to realise her full potential. "Across every field, women are shaping India's progress with determination, creativity and unmatched zeal. Their achievements inspire our nation and strengthen our collective resolve to build a Viksit Bharat," he said in a message. ^{PTI}

The Indian Women's Press Corps (IWPC) on Sunday reaffirmed its commitment to supporting safe, equitable, and empowering spaces for women in media, on the occasion of International Women's Day. The IWPC said that on this day, it celebrates the remarkable contributions of women in media across India, especially in far-flung remote areas, across diverse regions and languages where women continue to shape public discourse. It added that it was important that people listen to what women have to say in this ever-changing world, adding that they must have a say on agendas that shape the policies, systems and indeed the world. PTI

Punjab Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema on Sunday, presenting the State Budget for 2026-27, said ₹1,000 per month would be transferred directly to the bank accounts of all adult women under a new scheme, “*Mukh Mantri Mawan Dhian Satikar Yojana*”.

“Moreover, for women belonging to the Scheduled Caste community, the Bhagwant Mann government will transfer ₹1,500 per month directly to their accounts... Every woman in Punjab above 18 years of age will be eligible to enrol in this scheme, barring only a few, that is, existing or past permanent government employees, existing and past MPs, MLAs, and income tax payees,” Mr. Cheema said.

“...one of our neigh-



bouring States announced a similar scheme but limited it only to households with annual income under ₹1 lakh, covering only 20% of all adult women. But Punjab will not do such *jumlas*. Hon'ble Chief Minister Sardar Bhagwant Singh Mannji is not a Chief Minister for 20% of the women of Punjab, but to all the women of Punjab," the Minister said in an appa-

rent reference to Harvana.

“A dedicated budgetary outlay of ₹9,300 crore has been earmarked in the financial year 2026-27 to ensure transparent and timely implementation,” he added.

Mr. Cheema presented the Budget with a total outlay of ₹2,60,437 crore in the Punjab Assembly. "The effective revenue deficit and fiscal deficit are ex-

pected at 2.06% and at 4.08% of GSDP (Gross State Domestic Product), respectively," he said.

As per the Budget estimates, Punjab's effective outstanding debt for 2026-27 would stand at ₹4,42,604.16 crore, up from ₹4,02,633.51 crore in 2025-26 (revised estimates). The effective outstanding debt-to-GSDP ratio is estimated at 45.13% for 2026-27.

Opposition parties reacted sharply to the Budget, the last by the AAP government ahead of the Assembly election.

Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly Parthap Singh Bajwa said the scheme had been announced years late. "The AAP government promised ₹1,000 per month to every woman in 2022...This is not governance. This is election season politics," Mr. Bajwa said.

Assam CM announces ₹9,000 each for 40 lakh families under Orunodoi scheme; Manipur allocates ₹350 crore for women affected by conflict

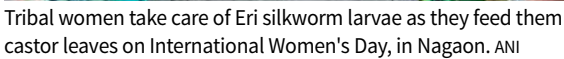
The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Assam and Manipur governments announced cash incentives for women and their families on Sunday, coinciding with International Women's Day.

In a social media broadcast on the seventh day of the Bharatiya Janata Party's Jan Ashirwad Yatra, Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said the State government would transfer ₹9,000 each to approximately 40 lakh beneficiary families under the Orunodoi scheme through direct benefit transfer (DBT) on Tuesday.

He urged the beneficiaries to attend special meetings at designated venues to receive the financial assistance. The total amount to be disbursed under the scheme would be about ₹3,600 crore, making it one of the largest financial assistance programmes in Assam.

The Chief Minister had earlier said the disburse-



ment would be the largest single-day transfer of funds to beneficiaries in Assam's history.

Launched on October 2, 2020, Orunodoi is a major DBT initiative aimed at empowering women and supporting poor families. The Chief Minister said the ₹9,000 included a Bihu bonus and four monthly instalments under the scheme from January to April.

In Imphal, Manipur

Chief Minister Yumnang Khemchand Singh announced ₹350 crore to be earmarked for assistance to women affected by the ethnic conflict. He said the amount for the next fiscal would benefit 3.5 lakh women in the State.

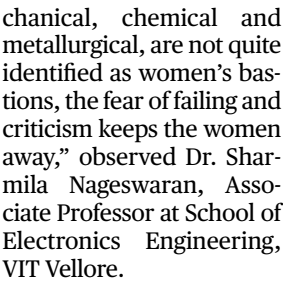
Speaking at an International Women's Day event, he hoped that people displaced by the "unprecedented crisis" in Manipur would be able to return home.

Three alumni of the Vellore Institute of Technology (VIT) took centre stage at a webinar on “From Campus To C-Suite: Women Engineers Leading India’s Tech Boom” on Sunday to share their career journeys and leadership experiences.

The webinar was organised by the VIT, Vellore, in collaboration with The Hindu Education Plus, as part of the Career Path series, to mark International Women's Day.

While opportunities exist and women are actively breaking the glass ceiling in engineering, barriers remain in reaching top leadership positions. The panelists spoke about the challenges they faced and shone light on key skills required to excel in competitive tech environments.

“Since certain engineer-



She said not every woman is motivated to take up an engineering course or a job, and the mindset of the family often decides her career path. "Women look after the family after motherhood, or they relocate for the spouse; so they need to be supported with Work From Home or online jobs," she suggested.

Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu on Sunday said that the State government would introduce a law guaranteeing 25% reservation for women in recruitment to Class 3 government posts. He was presiding over the State-level International Women's Day function held in Sirmaur district.

Asserting that the Congress government is committed to strengthening women's participation, he said a special recruitment drive for women sub-inspectors would be undertaken in the Police Department.

He said women's welfare remained the State government's top priority, with women at the heart of every policy initiative.

SUDOKU

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

Solution to previous puzzle

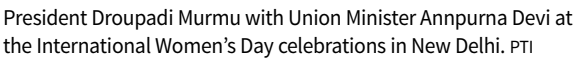
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Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

4	2	5	7	1	8	6	3	9
6	8	9	2	3	4	5	7	1
7	1	3	5	9	6	4	8	2
1	6	7	3	8	9	2	5	4
8	5	4	6	2	1	3	9	7
9	3	2	4	5	7	8	1	6
3	7	1	8	6	2	9	4	5
5	9	6	1	4	3	7	2	8
2	4	8	9	7	5	1	6	3

The Vedas illuminate the subtle paths of the divine journey that are otherwise unknown to us, presenting them through sacred narratives and prayers. Among these, the principles of charity are explained with great clarity and reverence. Charity, the Vedas declare, should be offered with complete dedication and a selfless heart. Sri Sundara Rama Vajapeya Swami, while expounding the significance of charity, cited the Rigveda, Eighth Ashtaka, Sixth Adhyaya. He explained that hunger repeatedly afflicts human life; though it cannot be eradicated entirely, it can be alleviated temporarily. Therefore, feeding the hungry is regarded as the most sacred and auspicious form of charity.

A person who practices charity attains the merit equivalent to the performance of yajnas and sacred rites. Such generosity transforms even adversaries into friends. In contrast, one who withholds charity finds that people do not befriend him. For those who practice charity, wealth moves in a continuous cycle, much like the revolving wheel of a temple chariot. Their riches never stagnate but return manifold through righteous circulation. In contrast, those who refuse to give, even while consuming wealth for themselves, are deemed to partake in sin, for enjoyment devoid of sharing is regarded as eating the fruits of one's own transgressions. We cannot expect everyone to be alike in the matter of charity. Even though both hands of a person appear similar and are equally formed, their strength and capacity are not the same. Likewise, each individual's ability to give differs, and charity must be understood and appreciated in accordance with one's means. Charity must be offered with humility.



Women are key to nation's progress: President Murmu

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

President Droupadi Murmu said on Saturday that women were not only the foundation of society but also the builders of the nation's future, emphasising that educated, self-reliant, and empowered women were central to a country's development.

Ms. Murmu was addressing the concluding session of a two-day national conference of women thinkers titled "*Bharti - Naari Se Narayani*" at Vigyan Bhavan.

The conference on Saturday and Sunday brought together around 1,500 women thinkers and professionals from across the country to deliberate

on issues such as women's empowerment, education, leadership, self-reliance and their role in nation-building.

The event was organised by the Rashtra Sevika Samiti, the women's wing of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh, along with Bhartiya Vidvat Parishad, which promotes research and studies in Indian shastras, and Sharanaya Organization, an affiliate of the Samiti working to promote education, skills, self-reliance and leadership among women from disadvantaged communities.

Ms. Murmu said women are equal to, and in many aspects even surpass, men in qualities such as service, dedication, nationalism, courage and patience.

Pre-okayed personal loans aid in emergency



Wise option: Pre-approved personal loans can complement savings. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

Santosh Agarwal

In a medical exigency, accessing funds is often key. Rising cost of healthcare, along with a high medical inflation rate, estimated between 12-15% a year, can cause distress. Lack of adequate health cover often leads families to depend on personal loans.

Waiting for approval with no clarity on eligibility can compound anxiety. Pre-approved personal loans, in such scenarios, are of huge value, enabling faster access to credit without much documentation.

How such loans help

Banks and NBFCs offer pre-approved personal loans, usually to existing consumers. Funds in these cases are credited within hours, often instantly. Pre-approved offers remove process friction via pre-assessed eligibility checks and enable credit certainty, seamless digital processes and shorter disbursal timelines.

At the same time, it aids borrowers avoid borrowing from informal sources, choose costlier options such as a loan on a credit card.

Borrowers get upfront clarity on the sanctioned loan and terms and conditions enabling more informed decision-making. This helps avoid chaotic borrowing, a financial trap that borrowers must avoid.

Interest rates on such loans based on prior credit assessment and borrower profile. It is usually offered to select customers of lenders, often at a more competitive pricing aligned with demonstrated creditworthiness.

Responsible utilisation

While emergencies call for immediate action, you should also exercise caution when taking a loan. A couple of things must be closely considered; first, thoroughly assessing your needs and second, borrowing as per your need and not your approved limit.

Assess repayment capacity realistically, taking into account current obligations and income stability before accepting any offer.

Equally important is understanding the total cost of borrowing. Processing fee, late payment levy, prepayment or foreclosure charges are some of the important charges adding to the total cost of the loan. Check with banks and NBFCs with whom you have an existing relationship for pre-approved offers, compare and pick judiciously.

Another aspect to consider is the loan tenure. A shorter tenure raises EMI compared with a longer tenure; however, with a longer tenure, the total interest outgo is more than the former. You should always choose a repayment structure that aligns with your financial capacity and cash flow.

There have been increasing instances where consumers in need of immediate funds have borrowed from poorly regulated/unregulated platforms, only to find themselves in a debt trap of high-interest loans, or, in some cases, exposed to fraudulent practices. To avoid falling prey to such scenarios, always borrow from RBI-regulated entities such as banks and large NBFCs.

Pre-approved personal loans, when used judiciously, complement savings by providing standby liquidity without friction. The objective is not to encourage mindless borrowing, but to enable informed, disciplined action when circumstances demand it.

(The writer is CEO of Paisabazaar)



ILLUSTRATION- SAAI

Porting hospitalisation policy; if this, then that

Starting porting process 45 days before renewal date is a requirement from the insurers' side; you have to start research earlier; renew old policy if needed, don't cancel it till you get the new policy

TO PORT OR NOT

K. Nitya Kalyani

Just as hospitalisation or any insurance for that matter, is individual specific, so is porting. There is no standard formula but let us see some good indications of who should port when, and when porting is not the best solution.

Better policies, service

Porting becomes an option for various reasons. You are unhappy with your insurance company's service or the policy you have. You notice that other companies appear to have better policies and service. Service includes customer service, promptness in addressing queries, concerns and evolving requirements whether by the insurer or his service providers like the TPA.

Of course it includes claims settlement, the touchstone of an insurance cover.

Your policy may have some constraints, including the inability to increase sum insured, sub-limits or co-pay that affect the scope of your claim, exclusions that other policies/insurers do not have, high premium rate and so on.

Frustration with service or an aspiration to get a better cover at a better rate is usually the reason most people think of porting. Here is a starter matrix for decision making.

When to port



Porting is an option for many reasons. You are unhappy with the policy you have or its service or you notice another insurer appears to have better policies, service.

You may consider porting if:

Age is on your side: The young and the middle-aged are likely to be in better health, have no major pre-existing diseases (PED). If they have lifestyle diseases, they are likely to be well-controlled.

Restrictive policy: You may have started quite some time ago with a low sum insured (SI) and, with a view to future, post-retirement age requirements, you want to raise it or need a policy that restores the SI.

Or, room rent and other expenditure caps force you to opt for lower category facilities or eat up your claim amount.

Better options: When its time for renewal, you will be snowed under by marketing calls offering better terms from SI to no sub limits to lower premium. While each of these is a reason to start homework on porting - please start two to three months before renewal because you need a clear 45 days to get this done without tears.

When not to port

And now, the reasons to stay with your current op-



Keep documentation safe; ensure you have running written correspondence with insurer, intermediaries; keep copies of old, new policy documents

tion:

You are senior citizen: Or are getting there shortly. As we saw in the previous instalment of this series, your health insurance options shrink as you age.

Your policy and service are good: You have compared options across a few companies and find you are on a good wicket with regard to clarity of terms and competency of rates.

Moreover, your insurer is responsive to your growing coverage requirements and you find claims being settled smoothly.

Also, when you have reliable TPA support and a wide network of and suitable hospitals in the cashless list, there is less reason to port out.

Waiting period over: Your specified procedures and PED waiting periods are done with, or almost so. If so, staying gives you stability that you should not risk for marginal benefits. There is also the risk of the company you wish to port to rejecting your proposal or loading your premium and/or restricting coverage.

This is especially applicable to senior citizens.

If you merely need more SI, make an effort to get this from your current insurer or by adding a top-up or super top-up policy rather than overhauling your entire coverage.

By this you leverage your existing relationship, medical tests may not be necessary and underwriting will be smooth. Getting a top-up with a different company is also an option.

How and how not

Other than insurer variables like underwriting and rating, your porting experience can be smooth if you handle it the right way.

Ensure your old policy is active until the new policy is issued.

Starting the porting process at least 45 days before the renewal date is a requirement from the companies' side. You have to start your research work earlier. Renew your old policy if needed and don't cancel it till you receive the new policy.

Keep your documentation clean and safe. Ensure you have running written correspondence with the insurance company and the intermediaries and keep copies of old and new policy documents, claim documents and payment proofs not to speak of communications regarding the porting request from the new company.

In case of future queries or disputes, documents are your best friends.

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history)

Can losses calibrate expectation?

THINKINVESTOR

We feel pain when actual investment experience falls short of expectations. But the pain recalibrates expectations. This can improve financial wellbeing.

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Investment losses may be crucial for financial wellbeing! In this article, we lean on behavioural psychology to show how losses can arguably improve your financial wellbeing.

Moderating expectations

Investment losses are emotionally painful. So are gains, when actual returns are lower than expected. That means emotional pain relating to investments can be attributed to actual returns falling short of our expectations. Can we moderate this pain by moderating our expectations?

Philosophically speaking, we should be able to do so. But the argument may not be practical as relative wealth, not absolute wealth, is typically the reference point driving desire. Most individuals are not satisfied with current lifestyle, regardless of income levels. When individuals have more than enough to meet basic lifestyle needs, it often becomes a continual race to improve existing lifestyle. The comparison is both to past lifestyle and current identifiable peers. There, moderating investment expectation may not work unless experience tells us to do so.

That is where experiencing realised and unrealised losses help. Suppose investments were to always generate positive returns. When you get used to, say, an annual return of 12%, your investment performance may not be emotionally satisfying. Call it the dopamine effect. Your brain is excited only when the actual experience is better than anticipated experience. When you earn the same return every year, your brain is no longer excited about the experience. You need more returns to feel the dopamine high. But if portfolio suffers losses after a series of positive returns, expectations are naturally moderated. When returns are positive the next year, you may be emotionally satisfied because your reference point, or anchor, has changed. Positive returns this year, even if lower, will feel better compared with the negative returns you experienced last year.

Conclusion

We feel pain when actual investment experience falls short of expectations. But the pain recalibrates expectations. This can improve financial wellbeing. For one, we may be satisfied with lower gains on investments. After all, a positive outcome, even if smaller, may appear better compared with a negative outcome. For another, lower expectations could have positive effect (or less negative effect) on physical health. The upshot? Investment losses are inevitable, but there may be some positive effects from the experience.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Bank Fixed Deposit Rates

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Small Finance Banks				
AU Small Finance Bank	7.10	6.35	7.10	6.75
Equitas Small Finance Bank	7.40	6.90	7.00	7.00
ESAF Small Finance Bank	8.00	4.75	6.00	5.75
Jana Small Finance Bank	7.77	7.00	7.50	7.77
Shivalik Small Finance Bank	7.80	6.00	6.75	6.25
slice Small Finance Bank	7.75	6.25	7.50	7.00
Suryoday Small Finance Bank	7.90	7.25	7.25	7.90
Ujjivan Small Finance Bank	7.45	7.25	7.20	7.20
Utkarsh Small Finance Bank	7.50	6.00	7.50	7.00
Private Sector Banks				
Axis Bank	6.45	6.25	6.45	6.45
Bandhan Bank	7.20	7.00	7.00	5.85
City Union Bank	7.00	6.80	6.50	6.25
CSB Bank	7.00	5.00	5.75	5.75
DBS Bank	6.60	6.30	6.40	6.25
DCB Bank	7.15	6.90	7.00	7.15
Federal Bank	6.70	6.25	6.70	6.40
HDFC Bank	6.45	6.25	6.45	6.40
ICICI Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.50
IDFC FIRST Bank	7.20	6.30	7.20	7.20
Indusind Bank	7.00	6.75	6.90	6.65

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Public Sector Banks				
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	7.25	6.75	6.65	6.60
IDBI Bank	6.50	6.20	6.35	6.25
Karnataka Bank	6.65	6.50	6.15	6.15
Kotak Mahindra Bank	6.70	6.50	6.40	6.25
RBL Bank	7.20	7.00	7.20	6.70
SBM Bank India	7.85	7.10	7.10	7.00
South Indian Bank	6.60	6.35	6.20	5.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.10	6.80	6.60	6.60
YES Bank	7.00	6.65	7.00	6.75
Public Sector Banks				
Bank of Baroda	6.45	6.10	6.25	6.30
Bank of India	6.60	6.25	6.25	6.00
Bank of Maharashtra	6.65	6.20	5.25	5.00
Canara Bank	6.50	6.25	6.25	6.25
Central Bank of India	6.50	6.20	6.00	6.00
Indian Bank	6.60	6.10	6.05	6.00
Indian Overseas Bank	6.60	6.50	6.10	6.10
Punjab National Bank	6.60	6.25	6.30	6.10
Punjab & Sind Bank	6.75	5.85	5.85	5.95
State Bank of India	6.45	6.25	6.30	6.05
Union Bank of India	6.60	6.30	6.25	6.00
Rates as of March 5				

Home Loan Interest Rates

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Public Sector Banks			
State Bank of India	7.25-8.70	7.25-8.70	7.25-8.70
Bank of Baroda	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.25
Union Bank of India*	7.15-9.50	7.15-9.50	7.15-9.50
Punjab National Bank	7.25-9.10	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.00
Bank of India	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.25
Bank of Maharashtra	7.10-9.90	7.10-9.90	7.10-9.90
Punjab and Sind Bank	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70
Indian Overseas Bank	7.10 #	7.10 #	7.10 #
Indian Bank	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55
Central Bank of India	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15
Private Sector Banks			
Kotak Mahindra Bank	7.70 #	7.70 #	7.70 #
ICICI Bank	7.45 #	7.45 #	7.45 #
Axis Bank	8.00-11.90	8.00-11.90	8.00 - 9.10
HSBC Bank	7.45 #	7.45 #	7.45 #
South Indian Bank	7.20 #	7.20 #	7.20 #
Karur Vysya Bank	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65
Karnataka Bank	7.30-11.68	7.30-11.68	7.30-11.68

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
Federal Bank	7.30 - 9.75	7.30 - 9.75	7.30 - 9.75
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30
Bandhan Bank	8.41-12.58	8.41-12.58	8.41-12.58
RBL Bank	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
CSB Bank	8.05 #	8.05 #	8.05 #
HDFC Bank	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
City Union Bank	8.25-9.50	8.50-10.00	8.75-10.50
Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
LIC Housing Finance	7.15 #	7.15 #	7.15 #
Bajaj Housing Finance	7.15 #	7.15 #	7.15 #
Tata Capital	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
PNB Housing Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
GIC Housing Finance	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
SMFG India Home Finance	10.00 #	10.00 #	10.00 #
Sammaan Capital	8.75 #	8.75 #	8.75 #
Aditya Birla Capital	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
ICICI Home Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
Godrej Housing Finance	7.60 #	7.60 #	7.60 #
*Extra 0.5% rate concession to borrowers taking insurance			
#Onwards Rates as on March 3 Source:Paisabazaar.com			

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.

WASHINGTON

'No accuracy': Trump says deadly strike on school carried out by Iran



AFP

U.S. President Donald Trump on Saturday blamed Iran for what the country's authorities said was a deadly strike on a school in Minab that killed over 150 people, mostly students. "We think it was done by Iran. Because they are very inaccurate, as you know, with their munitions. They have no accuracy whatsoever," Mr. Trump said. AFP

JERUSALEM

Three Palestinians killed in Israeli settler fire in occupied West Bank



REUTERS

Three Palestinians were killed during an Israeli settler attack in the occupied West Bank, the second deadly incident reported in as many days. Palestinian officials said settlers shot three dead in Abu Fala. "This is an unacceptable incident," Major General Avi Bluth, Israeli military chief in the West Bank, was quoted as saying. AFP

OSLO

Police begin probe into explosion outside U.S. Embassy in Norway



REUTERS

Oslo police said on Sunday an explosion at the U.S. Embassy in Norway that caused no injuries and minor material damage may have been an act of terror, but stressed they were probing other motives. Norway's Foreign Minister Espen Barth Eide called the incident "unacceptable" as search began for the perpetrators. AFP

HAVANA

Cuban leader calls Trump-hosted Latin American event 'neocolonial'



AFP

Cuban President Miguel Diaz-Canel said on Saturday that the Latin American summit convened by Donald Trump was "neocolonial," after the U.S. leader said the island nation is in "its final moments". Mr. Diaz-Canel said the U.S. has committed governments in the region "to accept use of U.S. force to resolve internal problems." AFP

Commission probing Nepal's Gen Z protests submits report to PM Karki

As many as 77 people lost their lives in the youth-led protests, including 19 killed in police firing, which led to the toppling of the K.P. Sharma Oli govt.; panel chief calls for report to be made public and recommends actions against all those involved

Sanjeev Satgainya
KATHMANDU

A commission to investigate the incidents during the Gen Z protests in September last year in Nepal submitted its report to Prime Minister Sushila Karki on Sunday.

The details of the report have not been made public, but the commission's chair, Gauri Bahadur Karki, a former judge, said it has recommended action against all those involved in the incidents of September 8 and 9 last year.

As many as 77 people lost their lives in the youth-led protests, including 19 killed in police firing on the



The panel also probed vandalism and arson during the protests. Demonstrators set fire to Singha Durbar on September 9, 2025. AP

first day, which led to the toppling of the K.P. Sharma Oli government. A new interim government led by Ms. Karki formed the commission on September 21.

"We minutely investigated the events of both days and have recommended

action against the guilty," Mr. Bahadur Karki told the media after submitting the report.

He did not specify who had been identified as perpetrators but said, "...those who opened fire, who ordered the firing,

and who did not stop it... all have been named."

The commission was also mandated to probe the vandalism and arson on the second day of the protests. On September 9, demonstrators burned down the Parliament building, the Supreme Court, and Singha Durbar – the complex housing government ministries – as well as hotels, business houses, and private properties.

The commission was initially given three months to complete its work, but its term was extended multiple times. The commission's last extended term is due to expire on Monday.

The three-member commission questioned

around 200 people, including then Prime Minister Oli and had submitted a 1,000-page report, with about 7,000 pages of annexures.

At the time of the protests, Chandra Kuber Khapung was the chief of Nepal police, while Chhabi Rijal was the chief district officer of Kathmandu and chair of the district security committee. Nepali Congress leader Ramesh Lekhak was the Home Minister.

Mr. Bahadur Karki said his commission had told the Prime Minister and the Cabinet that the report must be made public and the recommended actions implemented.

Close to 400 dead as Israeli strikes continue in Lebanon

Associated Press
DUBAI/BEIRUT

Israeli strikes on Lebanon have killed 394 people over the past week, including 83 children and 42 women, the country's Health Minister Rakan Nassereddine said on Sunday, after Israel expanded its attacks to a hotel in central Beirut.

Israel struck southern Lebanon and Beirut again on Sunday and killed 12 more people.

Israeli officials said the strikes targeted commanders of the Lebanese branch of Iran's Revolutionary Guards' Quds Force, after Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu promised "many surprises" for the next phase of the conflict. It said five were killed in the Beirut hotel strike, including 3 Iran Guards commanders.



Destroyed buildings in the southern Lebanese town of Kfar Kila as seen from across the border in northern Israel on Sunday. AFP

Israeli military said two of its soldiers were killed in southern Lebanon.

Meanwhile, more than 100 Iranians, including some diplomats, were evacuated from Beirut overnight, a Lebanese official said.

"A total of 117 Iranians, including diplomats and embassy staff, were evacuated on a Russian plane that left Beirut overnight

from Saturday to Sunday," the official said.

The evacuation comes after Lebanon had banned any activity by the Guards, a main backer of the militant group Hezbollah.

More than half a million people in Lebanon had been registered as displaced since the outbreak of the new war.

(With inputs from AFP, Reuters)

With an eye on Trump visit, China weighs Iran response

NEWS ANALYSIS

Ananth Krishnan

With a focus on U.S. President Donald Trump visiting Beijing next month, China appears to be carefully weighing its response to the Iran crisis, calibrating what would have ordinarily been a strong condemnation of massive military strikes on a close partner.

On Sunday, China's Foreign Minister and Politburo member Wang Yi, in his annual 90-minute remarks with Chinese and foreign journalists along the sidelines of the National People's Congress (NPC) or legislature, called for an end to "a war that should not have happened" and warned of the return of "the law of the jungle".

At the same time, it was made clear that preparations were in full swing to ensure Mr. Trump's upcoming visit to Beijing would be successful.

Mr. Wang also praised Mr. Trump, saying the Presidents of both countries were "leading by example" and "providing an important strategic safeguard for the China-U.S. relationship to improve and move forward", ahead of what he described as "a big year" for China-U.S. relations.

Mr. Wang took questions on issues China sees as its diplomatic priorities, including relations with the U.S., Russia, India and Japan – the only countries that received specific mention. He also broadly addressed China's ties with Europe, Latin America, Africa, ASEAN, and the Global South.

On India, the Chinese Foreign Minister said relations had been given a



Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi at a press conference in Beijing. AP

"fresh start" following the 2024 meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Xi Jinping in Kazan, and their second meeting in Tianjin last year when China hosted the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit. Mr. Xi is expected to visit India this year for the BRICS Summit, and Mr. Modi is likely to head to China when it is its turn to host next year.

Mr. Wang said both sides "must step up to the plate, and support each other's BRICS presidency over the next two years, so as to make BRICS cooperation more substantive and bring new hope to the Global South." He said Beijing was "heartened to see reenergised interactions at all levels, a new record in bilateral trade, and closer people-to-people exchanges."

'Partners, not rivals'

In addition to cooperating as part of BRICS, he put forward three other measures for relations, including maintaining "the correct strategic perception of each other as partner rather than rival, and opportunity instead of threat"; jointly safeguarding peace and stability in the border areas; and focusing on "development, which is the biggest common denominator of our two countries" to "produce more

visible outcomes of practical cooperation."

On Sunday, the ongoing Iran crisis and the China-U.S. relationship received the most attention. "This is a war that should not have happened," Mr. Wang said, repeating China's "calls for an immediate stop to military operations".

Beijing remains especially concerned about the implications to its energy security from continuing instability in West Asia, at a time when it is already dealing with economic headwinds at home. At the opening of the NPC last week, Chinese Premier Li Qiang's work report announced a lowering of China's GDP target to "4.5% to 5%".

Economic concerns also underpin Beijing's interest in ensuring economic relations with the U.S. remain on an even keel. Without naming the U.S., he said "a certain country is erecting tariff barriers and pushing economic and technological decoupling."

Mr. Wang downplayed the idea of a China-U.S. "G2", saying "there are more than 190 countries", but added that "the relationship between China and the U.S. is one of far-reaching and global implications." "Sliding into conflict or confrontation," he said, "could drag the whole world down."

International law 'effectively dead', says Kremlin aide

Press Trust of India
MOSCOW

Russia has said international law is effectively dead amid escalating tensions in West Asia following the U.S.-Israeli strike on Iran, and called for reviving President Vladimir Putin's proposal to convene a summit of the five permanent members of the UN Security Council.

Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov said the current global situation underscores the need to revisit Mr. Putin's proposal, first made before the COVID-19 pandemic, for a summit of the P-5 – Russia, the U.S., China, France and the U.K. – to discuss global security and stability.

"We have all lost what we call international law... I do not even understand how anyone can be called upon to follow the norms and principles of international law. It effectively no longer exists," Mr. Peskov said. He said international law exists "de jure" (by law) but no longer "de facto" (in fact).

Referring to the U.S.-Israeli attack on Iran, Mr. Peskov said the situation in the region has become significantly destabilised.

'U.S. must clarify plan'

Meanwhile, Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov said the U.S. should clarify its broader plans and explain how they relate to existing international norms.

"We talk a lot about wanting to define what kind of world we live in... We believe the U.S. should explain its plans and how this all relates to what previously defined certain norms," he said.

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PEAKING AT RIGHT TIME

Abhishek saves his best for the last, hammers half-century off 18 balls



EMMANUAL YOGINI

Abhishek Sharma couldn't have chosen a better day to jump into a motorcar and ride downtown. He did have two lucky escapes, but as they say, all's well that ends well. He reached his half-century off just 18 balls, the fastest of the 2026 T20 World Cup. Rachin Ravindra eventually claimed his wicket, but the damage had been done.

TWO TO TANGO

Records tumble as Abhishek and Samson have a ball in PowerPlay



EMMANUAL YOGINI

India demonstrated why it calls the first six overs of T20Is the PowerPlay, with Abhishek Sharma and Sanju Samson delivering the prologue of a run-fest. Ninety-two for no loss was not only the best a team fared in the PowerPlay in this edition of the T20 World Cup, but also the joint-highest overall (WI vs. AFG, 2024).

GOING BERSERK

India registers the highest T20 total at Narendra Modi Stadium



VIJAY SONEJI

The lines blurred between Ahmedabad and Monza as India raced to 255/5. Despite Jimmy Neesham applying the brakes in the 16th over with three wickets, a scary-looking Indian batting line-up put on a scarier-looking total. It was not only the highest T20 score at the venue but also the third-highest total in a T20 World Cup game.

MASTER'S INFLUENCE

Player-of-the-Tournament Samson reveals Tendulkar's vital inputs



VIJAY SONEJI

I've been in constant touch with Sachin Tendulkar sir. When I was out of the team in Australia, I thought about what mindset I had to be in. I reached out to him and had long conversations with him. Yesterday [Saturday], he called me up to check how I was feeling. I'm very grateful to everyone who supported me — Sanju Samson.

A red-letter day for the Men in Blue

Samson extends his merry run with a 46-ball 89; Abhishek and Kishan, too, slam quick-fire fifties to power India to 255 for five; Bumrah proves his class yet again as the Kiwis are shot out for 159

T20 WORLD CUP FINAL

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
AHMEDABAD

On the road to the Narendra Modi Stadium, a banner proclaimed: 'Some days are green, some days are red, today is all about blue'. The Men in Blue lived up to that billing during a rousing Sunday night. Among the list of milestone dates in India's limited-overs cricketing history — June 25, 1983; September 24, 2007; April 2, 2011; and June 29, 2024 — add March 8, 2026. At a packed venue, the defending champion dished out a commanding performance to claim the ICC T20 World Cup after defeating New Zealand by 96 runs. This was India's fifth World Cup triumph, including two in ODIs and three in T20Is.

Early wickets
Pursuing India's 255 for five, New Zealand was bowled out for 159 in 19 overs. Suryakumar Yadav's men buzzed around, and the chase was a non-starter as Finn Allen failed to capitalise on a dropped catch by Shivam Dube, and succumbed to Axar Patel. It got worse when Rachin Ravindra tried to flick Jasprit Bumrah over backward square-leg. A sprinting Ishan Kishan dived full length and plucked a stunner. And when Axar pegged back the stumps of Glenn Phillips, the Black Caps were wobbling at 47 for three.



The reign continues: Team India outplayed New Zealand on an unforgettable Sunday to assert its supremacy in the shortest format of the game. EMMANUAL YOGINI

Opener Tim Seifert who thumped 20 from a Hardik Pandya over, tried to keep the fires burning. But when Hardik dismissed Mark Chapman and Seifert (52) perished to Varun Chakaravathy, the rivals were down for the count. Skipper Mitchell Santner tried to delay the inevitable, landing some blows, before Bumrah ensured that India won with ease. Earlier, Santner won the

toss, elected to field, and watched Indian openers Sanju Samson and Abhishek Sharma flourish in the PowerPlay. The two amassed 92 runs in the first six overs even as Santner switched his bowlers around. Initially, Matt Henry kept it tight and Samson remained watchful as four dot balls ensued. However, a six over long-on in the first over, opened the floodgates.

Seeing his partner switch gears, Abhishek warmed up with fours off Jacob Duffy on either side while the New Zealand seamers struggled with a bout of wides. Abhishek raced to his fifty, dismantling Henry with two sixes, and wading into Duffy. The southpaw fell to Rachin but the openers had stitched together 98 runs in 7.1 overs. Soon Kishan warmed up

with a four off Jimmy Neesham, and hoisted Santner into the stands. Meanwhile, Samson etched his 50, and with celebratory gusto pumelled Lockie Ferguson twice into the skies. Kishan too got into the gravity defying act as the ball sailed high. Rachin was clattered around and after Kishan got to his fifty, against the run of play, New Zealand inflicted three wounds.

Neesham scalped Samson (89), Kishan (54) and Suryakumar (nought) in the same over, as the batters found alert fielders. India 204 for four in 16 overs, and on the hunt for quick runs. A quest Hardik tried to fulfil, before Dube hammered Neesham for 24 in the last over. And at the break, India nursed its dreams about retaining the championship, which it did in style.

Honours board

2007	India
2009	Pakistan
2010	England
2012	West Indies
2014	Sri Lanka
2016	West Indies
2021	Australia
2022	England
2024	India
2026	INDIA

SCOREBOARD

INDIA
Sanju Samson c (sub) McConchie b Neesham 89 (46b, 5x4, 8x6), Abhishek Sharma c Seifert b Rachin 52 (21b, 6x4, 3x6), Ishan Kishan c Chapman b Neesham 54 (25b, 4x4, 4x6), Hardik Pandya c Santner b Henry 18 (13b, 1x4, 1x6), Suryakumar Yadav c Rachin b Neesham 0 (1b), Tilak Varma (not out) 8 (6b), Shivam Dube (not out) 26 (8b, 3x4, 2x6); Extras (w-8); 8; Total (for five wkts. in 20 overs): 255.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-98 (Abhishek, 7.1 overs), 2-203 (Samson, 15.1), 3-204 (Kishan, 15.5), 4-204 (Suryakumar, 15.6), 5-226 (Hardik, 18.2).

NEW ZEALAND BOWLING
Henry 4-0-49-1, Phillips 1-0-5-0, Duffy 3-0-42-0, Ferguson 2-0-48-0, Santner 4-0-33-0, Rachin 2-0-32-1, Neesham 4-0-46-3.

NEW ZEALAND
Tim Seifert c Kishan b Varun 52 (26b, 2x4, 5x6), Finn Allen c Tilak b Axar 9 (7b, 1x4), Rachin Ravindra c Kishan b Bumrah 1 (2b), Glenn Phillips b Axar 5 (5b, 1x4), Mark Chapman b Hardik 3 (8b), Daryl Mitchell c Kishan b Axar 17 (11b, 2x6), Mitchell Santner b Bumrah 43 (35b, 3x4, 2x6), James Neesham b Bumrah 8 (7b, 1x4), Matt Henry b Bumrah 0 (1b), Lockie Ferguson (not out) 6 (7b), Jacob Duffy c Tilak b Abhishek 3 (5b); Extras (b-4, lb-1, w-7); 12; Total (in 19 overs): 159.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-31 (Allen, 2.4), 2-32 (Rachin, 3.1), 3-47 (Phillips, 4.5), 4-70 (Chapman, 7.4), 5-72 (Seifert, 8.1), 6-124 (Mitchell, 12.5), 7-141 (Neesham, 15.3), 8-141 (Henry, 15.4), 9-152 (Santner, 17.3).

INDIA BOWLING
Arshdeep 4-0-32-0, Hardik 4-0-36-1, Axar 3-0-27-3, Bumrah 4-0-15-4, Varun 3-0-39-1, Abhishek 1-0-5-1.

Toss: New Zealand.
Player-of-the-Match: Bumrah.
Player-of-the-Tournament: Samson.
India won by 96 runs to retain the World Cup.

Delivering on the big night



The architects: Samson ensured India seized the initiative with another sparkling knock before Bumrah took the wind out of New Zealand's sails. EMMANUAL YOGINI & VIJAY SONEJI



Indian cricket in safe hands: Gambhir

Santadeep Dey
AHMEDABAD

After 840 days of crying over spilt milk, the odd Indian cricket fan finally got to have the (cup)cake and eat it as Suryakumar Yadav and Co. flipped the script at the Narendra Modi Stadium here on Sunday. The 2023 ODI final loss is now well and truly a thing of the past. "Very happy. It will take a little bit of time to sink in. Have just come out of a good game at home. When we wake up tomorrow, it will be a special feeling," the Indian captain said after recording a massive 96-run win against New Zealand. Suryakumar also reserved praise for coach Gautam Gambhir, who sat beside the skipper at the press conference. He said, "I knew Gauti bhai's expectations of me. There were so many times when we were both picking a team of 14 players and still ended up picking the same people. The camaraderie was



Cynosure of all eyes: Suryakumar poses for the shutterbugs after guiding the team to a historic third title in the showpiece as Hardik looks on. VIJAY SONEJI

always there. There have been no arguments because we were always focussed on what was beneficial for the team." Gambhir had a long list of people to thank. He said, "Indian cricket is in such good shape because of Rahul (Dravid) bhai. V.V.S. Laxman has uncon-

ditionally worked hard at (the BCCI) CoE to look after the pipeline of Indian cricket. Ajit Agarkar has worked with a lot of honesty. And lastly Jay (Shah) bhai, because not many people have called me when I was at the lowest point of my life. Until these guys are there, I think In-

dian cricket is in very, very safe hands." Suryakumar and Gambhir leave the hall knowing it is time for the party to rage long into the good night. They would want to soak in the moment until yet another T20 carnival swoops in in about three weeks' time.



On target: The Indian players had plenty of moments to celebrate as they got the campaign off to a fine start. K.V.S. GIRI

India proves too good for Uruguay in opener

Sunelita, Ishika, Lalremsiami and Rutuja find the mark for the host; Scotland edges Wales in another Pool B match; England has it east against Italy while South Korea scrapes past Austria

WWC QUALIFIERS
Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

India opened its FIH Women's Hockey World Cup Qualifiers campaign on a strong note, defeating a spirited Uruguayan side 4-0 at the G.M.C. Balayogi Hockey Ground on Sunday. The host began on the front foot, dominating possession (59% in all) and pressing hard for an early breakthrough. However, India's inability to pick the right final pass, coupled with Uruguay's resolute

defence, ensured the opening quarter ended goalless. It wasn't for lack of trying, though. Udit's probing run down the left flank appeared to have given India the lead when the rebound found the net, but the raucous celebrations on and off the turf were short-lived as the referee ruled out the goal for having breached the height of the board. The second quarter saw the attack shift to the right, with Navneet Kaur leading in the charge. She won India's second penalty corner, and this time the home team was not to be denied. Debutant Annu's drag-flick

took a deflection off Sunelita Toppo's stick and beat goalkeeper Maria Bate to hand India a deserved lead. A penalty corner earned a minute before the half-time break raised hopes of an Uruguayan equaliser. But Sushila Chanu's timely interception maintained status quo. India doubled the lead in the 40th minute when Agustina Diaz failed to stop Ishika's strike on the goal line. India added a third goal four minutes into the final quarter, with Rutuja Pisal setting up Lalremsiami, whose effort flew past the helpless goalkeeper. With just two mi-

nutes in the contest, Rutuja ran unchecked into the circle and beat Miranda Martinez with a thumping strike, enough to catch a deep-in-conversation head coach Sjorde Marijne pleasantly off guard. India, all three points in hand, rose to the top of the Pool B standings, above Scotland, which beat Wales 1-0 earlier. The results: England 5 (Baldson 12-pc & 32-pc, Bingham 15, Neal 16-pc, Toman 27-pc) bt Italy 2 (Pessina 19-pc, Carta 46-pc); Korea 1 (Seona 34) bt Austria 0; Scotland 1 (Costello 20) bt Wales 0; India 4 (Sunelita 21-pc, Ishika 40, Lalremsiami 49, Rutuja 58) bt Uruguay 0.

Dominant Russell leads a Mercedes 1-2 finish; Leclerc takes third spot

AUSTRALIAN GP
Agence France-Presse
MELBOURNE

George Russell kept his cool to win a frantic season-opening Australian Grand Prix on Sunday from Mercedes teammate Kimi Antonelli after a thrilling battle with Ferrari's Charles Leclerc. The pole-sitting Briton took the chequered flag by 2.974s with Leclerc third and Lewis Hamilton fourth in a race that tested Formula One's new look cars for the first time in competitive conditions. World champion Lando Norris came fifth – 51s adrift – in his McLaren with Red Bull's Max Verstappen sixth after starting from 20th following a crash in qualifying. But there was disaster for home hero Oscar Piastri, who crashed on his out-lap to the grid and failed to start with major damage to his McLaren. With the virtual safety car repeatedly brought out, pre-season favourite Russell stayed calm to clock a sixth Grand Prix win and his first since Singapore last year. Under new rules, half of every power unit now is a battery and drivers had to recharge while braking or by lifting off the throttle to avoid it draining. Five cars failed to finish as they grappled with the changes, including Piastri, Audi's Nico Hulkenberg, Red Bull's Isack Hadjar, Cadillac's Valtteri Bottas and Aston Martin's Fernando Alonso. Haas' Ollie Bearman was seventh and rookie Arvid Lindblad eighth in his Racing Bull. Audi's Gabriel

Lights to flag

1 For the first time in his career, Russell leads the drivers' championship after a dominant win in the season opener

2 The points scored by Audi on its F1 debut, courtesy Bortoletto's ninth-place finish

3 Lindblad (18y 7m 1d) becomes the third youngest driver to get on the scoresheet after Verstappen (17y 5m 29d) and Antonelli (18y 6m 19d)

20 Hamilton has led a race at least once every year for 20 consecutive seasons, extending his

own record

26 The number of races since Mercedes had a 1-2 finish, the previous one coming at Las Vegas, 2024. This was also Mercedes' first 1-2 result without Hamilton as one of its drivers since the 1955 Italian GP

35 Russell has gone past championships for the fourth-most successive finishes

151 Leclerc has pulled level with Raikkonen for the second-most starts with Ferrari

181 Ocon has joined Grosjean as the driver with most starts without a pole position

1624 The number of days since a Mercedes driver last led the drivers' championship after Hamilton in the 2021 Russian GP

Compiled by ANIRUDH VELAMURI and S. DIPAK RAGAV

Bortoletto and Alpine's Pierre Gasly rounded out the top 10. 54.617. +1 lap: 7. Ollie Bearman (Haas); 8. Arvid Lindblad (Racing Bulls); 9. Gabriel Bortoletto (Audi); 10. Pierre Gasly (Alpine); 11. Esteban Ocon (Haas); 12. Alexander Albon (Williams); 13. Liam Lawson (Racing Bulls); +2 laps: 14. Franco Colapinto (Alpine); 15. Carlos Sainz (Williams); +3 laps: 16. Sergio Perez (Cadillac). NC: Lance Stroll (Aston Martin); DNF: Fernando Alonso (Aston Martin); Valtteri Bottas (Cadillac); Isack Hadjar (Red Bull). DNS: Oscar Piastri (McLaren); Nico Hulkenberg (Audi). Standings: Drivers: 1. Russell 25; 2. Antonelli 18; 3. Leclerc 15; 4. Hamilton 12; 5. Norris 10. Constructors: 1. Mercedes 43; 2. Ferrari 27; 3. McLaren 10; 4. Red Bull 8; 5. Haas 6.

THE HINDU GROUP

FAST-FORWARD IS ABOUT TO TAKE THE SPOTLIGHT.

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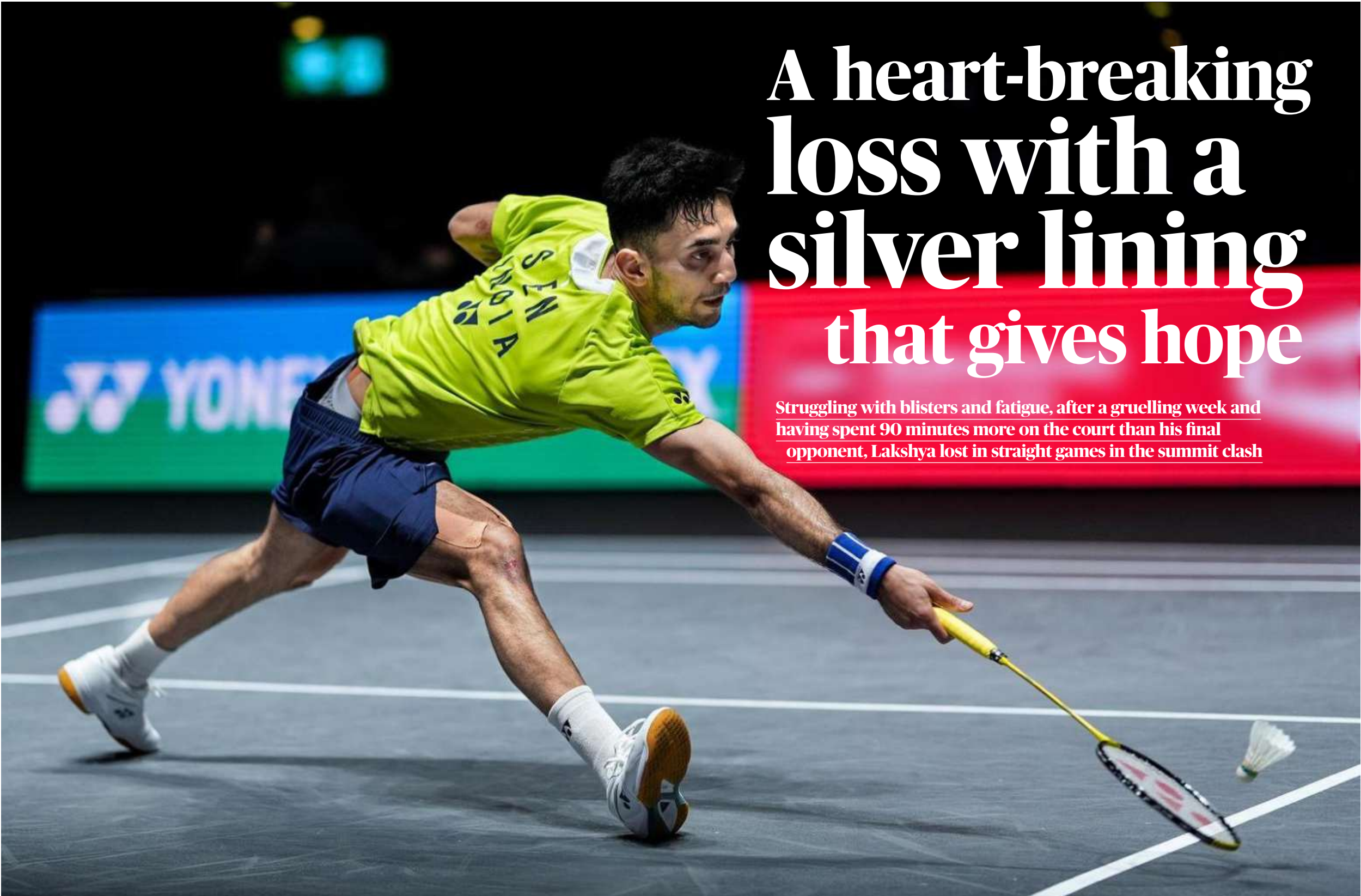
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GETTY IMAGES

A heart-breaking loss with a silver lining that gives hope

Struggling with blisters and fatigue, after a gruelling week and having spent 90 minutes more on the court than his final opponent, Lakshya lost in straight games in the summit clash

Devyanshi Bihani

Lakshya Sen's spirited run at the All England Open ended just short of history on Sunday as the Indian shuttler finished runner-up after losing the men's singles final to Taiwan's Lin Chun-Yi in Birmingham.

The defeat meant India's wait for an All England men's singles champion continued, with only two Indians – Prakash Padukone in 1980 and P. Gopi Chand in 2001 – having previously lifted the prestigious title.

For Lakshya, it was a second heartbreak at the sport's oldest tournament. Four years after finishing runner-up in 2022 following a loss to then World No.1 Viktor Axelsen, the 24-year-old once again came agonisingly close to the crown after producing one of the most impressive runs of his career through the draw.

The 24-year-old entered the final riding the momentum of a week that had already featured a stunning upset of World No.1 Shi Yuqi, a gritty comeback against Ng Ka Long Angus, a tactically assured win over Li Shifeng and a marathon semifinal triumph over Canada's Victor Lai.

Dethroning the king

The week began with a statement victory. Four years ago at the All England final, Lakshya was stopped by the World No.1 Viktor Axelsen. In 2026, he began his campaign against another World No. 1 and defending champion Shi Yuqi.

Lakshya produced one of the biggest upsets of the opening round. He pulled off a thrilling 23-21, 19-21, 21-17 victory to knock out the top seed in the opening round in a gripping contest that lasted 78 minutes. It was his earliest exit from a tournament since the Thailand Open in 2023.

The World No. 12 relied heavily on explosive forearm-driven smashes and deceptive wristwork, repeatedly unsettling the world champion and forcing him onto the back foot.

What stood out most was how Lakshya turned Yuqi's own strength against him. Widely regarded as one of the circuit's most deceptive players, the Chinese shuttler found himself repeatedly wrong-footed as Sen used subtle wrist disguises and late changes of direction to manipulate rallies. The Indian also controlled the front court smartly, using delicate net play to draw lifts before unleashing steep, hard smashes that steadily piled pressure on the top seed.

After the defeat, Yuqi admitted he was not at his best physically, revealing he had entered the tournament with limited preparation.

Tricky challenge

The second round presented another challenge: Hong Kong's Ng Ka Long Angus.

Angus had historically troubled

Lakshya, entering the contest with a 3-0 head-to-head advantage over the Indian. The Hong Kong shuttler signalled his intent right from the start, engaging Sen in a first rally that stretched beyond 40 shots.

Lakshya made the brighter start, pocketing the opening game 21-19 and carrying that momentum into the second. But as coach Vimal Kumar had said, "Angus is not easy at all," the veteran leaned on his deceptive overheads and rally-building, drawing Sen into extended exchanges before capitalising on the Indian's impatience to reel off five consecutive points and swing the game back in his favour.

"He made a solid comeback on the second. And I just didn't play freely towards the end of the second set. And just gave too many easy shots for him to kill. But I was prepared in the third set, to go all out..." Lakshya told the BWF.

And that response was emphatic. What could have turned into a nervy battle lasted barely longer than necessary. Lakshya tightened his defence, repeatedly pushing Angus deep into the backhand corner and dictating the rallies from the mid-court. He sealed the match 21-10 in the decider, ensuring that the brief wobble in the second game cost him nothing more than a few extra minutes on court.

Tactical precision

The quarterfinal against China's Li Shifeng required a different kind of solution. Unlike Angus, who relied on grit and long rallies, Shifeng is built to dominate the forecourt and dictate play from the net with explosive attacks. Rather than confronting him in that space, Lakshya chose to stretch the court.

He repeatedly pushed the shuttle deep into Shifeng's forehand rear corner, an area that disrupted the Chinese player's preferred front-court positioning and forced him to chase from awkward angles.

Lakshya's plan in the opening game was clear: keep the shuttle travelling to Shifeng's deep forehand corner. A mix of pushes, drops, lifts and smashes from that flank helped him take the game 21-13.

Shifeng briefly threatened to claw his way back in the second with powerful smashes and improved control at the net, but Lakshya refused to rush the rallies. By staying patient and keeping the shuttle in play, he gradually forced the Chinese player into errors, several of them wild attempts to force attacking winners from difficult positions. The Indian then pulled away late to close out the game 21-16 and wrap up the match in straight sets.

Semifinal marathon

The semifinal against Canada's Victor Lai turned into a draining duel that tested Lakshya's resilience as much as his badminton.

Lai is not known for breathtaking winners, but for something more exhausting, his ability to return almost everything. Rally after rally, the Canadian

The Indian had arrived without the tag of a favourite, but what followed was one of the most impressive campaigns of his career

kept the shuttle alive, forcing Lakshya to work relentlessly for points. The exchanges grew longer and longer, turning the contest into a gruelling endurance battle.

At one stage in the deciding game, the pair produced an extraordinary 86-shot rally, a moment that summed up the physical demands of the match. By the time the contest stretched past the hour mark and eventually reached 97 minutes, both players were visibly running on fumes.

Lakshya's struggle became evident at the final change of ends in the decider. Dealing with a blister on his foot and cramps creeping into his legs, he lay flat near his bench as his support staff massaged his tightening muscles. The chair umpire even told him that he had to either continue playing or retire under the rules.

But Lakshya pushed on.

"Starting the third set, I could feel cramps in my legs and I didn't know if I could go all the way. I was just trying to fight every point," Lakshya said later.

Realising that prolonged rallies would only worsen the cramps, Lakshya altered his approach in the closing stages. Instead of engaging in endless exchanges with Lai's stubborn defence, he began attacking earlier in rallies, looking to finish points quickly.

Fighting through exhaustion and pain, Lakshya closed out the match 21-16, 18-21, 21-15; even Lai admitted that the Indian was "mentally stronger." He secured his place in the All England final for the second time in his career.

No respite

Waiting on the other side was Taiwan's Lin Chun-Yi, a left-hander known for his powerful attacking game and sharp angles.

Lin managed to edge the opening game, while Lakshya, still carrying the fatigue from the marathon semifinal a day earlier, even required treatment for his shoulder and leg during the interval.

The Indian finalist managed to find his rhythm in the second game.

His cross smashes to the Lin's backhand and steep returns to stretch the Taiwanese diagonally across the court and with down the line returns he surged into a five point lead midway. Lin looked visibly puzzled and walked nervously up and down the court, conceding three or four easy points.

The contest reached fever pitch at 14-14 when the two traded relentless attacking strokes and desperate defensive pickups in the longest rally of the match, a breathtaking exchange of over 40 shots that had both players firing what felt like bullets across the net.

Sen continued to target Lin's backhand with cross smashes whenever he needed to regain control, but the closing stages turned into a nerve-racking shootout. With the score locked at 20-20 and both players attacking at full speed, Lin gained the advantage and stood one point away from the title before Lakshya's return drifted wide.

"Being able to play this tournament and winning it is a dream come true," Lin said post-match. He became the first player from Taiwan to win the All England men's singles title.

After the match, Lakshya admitted he had not been in ideal physical condition.

"But when I was playing on court, I was not thinking about anything but to give my best. Yesterday I was struggling a bit with cramps, but I had some time to recover. I couldn't recover 100%. Towards the end of the week, all the players were tired with four or five matches. It could have been better, but this is what I had. I gave everything," he said.

Reflecting on the final itself, Lakshya added: "The first set... I think he was a better player, but in the second game I could have finished off better. But I'm happy with the way I played throughout the week. I'm feeling emotional right now, thinking about the match. But

overall, lots of positive things."

Despite the loss in the final, Lakshya's run in Birmingham reaffirmed his status among the world's elite. Ranked World No. 12 coming into the tournament, the Indian had arrived without the tag of a favourite, but what followed was one of the most impressive campaigns of his career. The defeat of world No.1 Shi Yuqi and a semifinal performance that tested every ounce of his endurance. For now, the wait for an Indian men's singles champion at the All England tournament continues. But if this tournament proved anything, it is that Lakshya remains one of the players most capable of ending that wait. And perhaps soon.

THE GIST

- Despite the loss in the final, Lakshya's run in Birmingham reaffirmed his status among the world's elite
- After the title decider, Lakshya admitted he had not been in ideal physical condition
- For now, the wait for an Indian men's singles champion at the All England tournament continues. But if this tournament proved anything, it is that Lakshya remains one of the players most capable of ending that wait



GETTY IMAGES

Why India’s ‘leaky pipeline’ in research is unlike rest of the world

Most women Ph.D. holders in STEM in India are unable to access long-term research jobs, creating a position gap, where women scientists often have to contend with precarious contractual positions, positions without full-spectrum benefits, promotions or increments, and roles with limited career advancement

Karishma S. Kaushik

Girls and women represent half the population of the world yet their participation in scientific research is lagging. In many countries, this disparate contribution starts as early as school. In the U.S., for example, girls are less likely to take advanced calculus, physics, mathematics, and biology at high school level. In many other countries, the number of girls opting to major in a science, technology, engineering or mathematics (STEM) subject is significantly lower than that of boys. Women constitute only 35% of STEM graduates across the world and earn only 40% of STEM Ph.Ds. Further, based on data from 146 nations, women scientists comprise only 30% of the STEM workforce, which includes academic jobs and faculty positions. This systematic loss of women at various stages of STEM education and careers is commonly called the ‘leaky pipeline’. And at first glance, India appears to be an exception.

Where are the ‘leaks’? At the school level, nearly all students have ‘science’ as a mandatory subject and (at least anecdotally) girls participate in science quizzes, Olympiads, summer schools, hackathons, and hands-on tinkering challenges. After Class 10, the enrolment of girls in the ‘science’ stream can be as high as 60%, with girls making up 46% of all Class 12 science pass-outs. In 2025 the Ministry of Education reported that for the first time in over a decade, more girls had cleared their Class 12 examination in science than in the arts stream. This indicated a significant increase in the participation of girls in science education: according to data from 2014, 7.5 lakh more girls graduated from the arts stream than science. As a result, India boasts the highest percentage of female STEM graduates worldwide, with 43% women science graduates at the bachelor’s level and nearly 50% at the Masters and doctoral levels. But beyond the encouraging statistics, India does have a leaky pipeline for women in STEM – except that it looks different from the rest of the world. In spite of producing the highest number of female STEM graduates, women constitute only 18% of the research and development workforce in the country. A Department of Science and Technology report reveals that women constituted less than 30% of scientists in India’s national research agencies; the highest representation was in the Indian Council of Medical Research at 29% and



While women in India enter STEM education in large numbers, they are under-represented in scientific research jobs. UNSPLASH

the lowest in the Defence Research and Development Organisation at 14%. Women also make up only 8% of faculty at the Indian Institute of Science Bangalore and 11-13% of scientists at the IITs. While university settings, both government and private, report higher representation, the figures are still lower than 30%.

The typical Indian milieu What this means is that while women in India enter STEM education in large numbers, they are under-represented in scientific research jobs. This ‘leaky pipeline’ persists due to a combination of social, structural, and systemic challenges. In schools, girls in India are often encouraged to pursue science and those interested in science are considered to be ‘good’ or ‘smart’ girls, with ‘wanting to become a scientist’ looked upon favourably by teachers, peers, and parents. Yet as women advance in their science education – the pursuit of which can require several years of training and commitment – social expectations pose barriers to their career plans. Completing a Ph.D. often coincides with the search for a research job as well as familial directives to ‘settle down’, bear children, and ‘focus’ on the household. In India’s typical socio-cultural milieu, women often relocate to their husband’s place of living, adjust to a new family structure, and handle the larger share of childcare and

The big ‘leak’ in India’s STEM pipeline, as seen by the sharp loss of women scientists during the transition from science education to the research workforce, is a consequence of social, structural, and systemic challenges

household responsibilities, all of which pose significant challenges to seeking lucrative scientific research jobs and positions. Scientific recruitment across government research organisations have strict age cut-offs, especially at entry-level positions, in addition to erratic hiring practices, a dearth of positions, and specific mandates for certain fields of research. For women, given geographic constraints and familial responsibilities, accessing these long-term jobs means doing so within the age eligibility and in a defined location, factors that result in a limited pool of options. Academic jobs also don’t allow for remote work; while certain roles may allow for flexible and hybrid work models, they typically don’t directly involve research or teaching. **Position gap** At the level of the research ecosystem, some of these social and structural challenges are being addressed via special

recruitment drives and funding schemes for women scientists. In spite of these measures, institutions lag in ensuring gender parity at the time of recruitment, and gender equity initiatives have either been limited to pilot projects, are not appropriately incentivised, or are associated with minimal accountability. Consequently, the majority of women Ph.D. holders in STEM in India find themselves unable to access long-term, lucrative and prestigious research jobs. This results in a position gap, where women scientists often have to contend with short-term, contractual, precarious, and unstable positions, such as those found in quasi-academic initiatives, entities funded on grants, fellowships, or ‘soft money’, positions without full-spectrum benefits, promotions or increments, and roles with limited career advancement. The big ‘leak’ in India’s STEM pipeline, as seen by the sharp loss of women scientists during the transition from science education to the research workforce, is a consequence of social, structural, and systemic challenges -- and is reflected in the position gap that precludes the majority of trained women scientists from long-term and sustained participation in scientific research. (Karishma S Kaushik is a physician-scientist and scientific consultant. She has recently published a book for girls and women seeking to pursue STEM education and careers. karishmaskaushik@gmail.com)

THE GIST

- ▼ In many countries, the number of girls opting to major in a science, technology, engineering or mathematics (STEM) subject is significantly lower than that of boys
- ▼ In India, however, after Class 10, the enrolment of girls in the ‘science’ stream can be as high as 60%, with girls making up 46% of all Class 12 science pass-outs
- ▼ In spite of producing the highest number of female STEM graduates, women constitute only 18% of the research and development workforce in the country
- ▼ As women advance in their science education, social expectations and systemic challenges pose barriers to their career plans

BIG SHOT



An aerial view of iceberg A23a on January 19, 2024, in the Southern Ocean off the Antarctica coast. Once the largest on earth, A23a has reportedly reached the final stages of its four-decade life as it drifts into the warmer waters of the South Atlantic Ocean. On March 5, it was just north of South Georgia island.AFP

WHAT IS IT?

Cooling effect: on the wane

Vasudevan Mukunth

A new study published in *Geophysical Research Letters* has confirmed that global warming has entered a phase of significant acceleration. For decades, the earth’s temperature rose at a steady rate of about 0.2 degree Celsius per decade. Recent record-breaking years sparked a debate among scientists about whether this pace was increasing but natural events such as volcanic eruptions and solar cycles frustrated efforts to find a definitive answer. University of Potsdam researchers addressed this by stripping away these natural factors from five major global temperature datasets to reveal what they have said is a clearer underlying trend. Per their analysis, reported with 98% confidence, global warming has indeed accelerated, with the shift becoming statistically significant around the year 2015. In fact, the earth appears to have warmed faster over the last decade than during any other decade on record. The authors said the cause was likely a drop in aerosol levels: these pollutants reflect sunlight and mask some of the warming caused by greenhouse gases. But as countries cleaned up air pollution, they inadvertently removed their cooling effect, allowing the world to feel the full heat of global warming. The implications are urgent. The



Students carrying umbrellas stand on the dry riverbed of the Jialing River, a tributary of the Yangtze, in China’s Chongqing Municipality on August 19, 2022. AP

researchers have projected that at the newfound rate, the earth could breach the 1.5 °C limit established by the Paris Agreement by 2030. In turn this suggests that current efforts to curb emissions are insufficient and that to buck this trend, humankind may have to reach net-zero emissions far more quickly.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

People killed in drone strikes on markets in Sudan

33 The strikes targeted the markets of Abu Zabad and Wad Banda in West Kordofan state — part of the resource-rich Kordofan region that is currently the fiercest battlefield in the war between Sudan's army and the paramilitary RSF. AFP

Iranian sailors of *IRIS Dena* discharged from Sri Lankan hospital

22 At least 22 Iranian sailors of *IRIS Dena*, the Iranian ship that was torpedoed by the U.S., have been discharged, hospital authorities said on Sunday. Another 10 sailors remain under treatment at the National Hospital Galle in Karapitiya. PTI

Punjab government's State Budget allocation for 2026-2027

2,60,437 in ₹ cr. Every promise made to the people of Punjab has been fulfilled, Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema said as he presented the Budget for 2026-27. PTI

Death toll from Israeli strikes on Lebanon in the last week

394 Israeli strikes on Lebanon have killed 394 people in the last week, including 83 children and 42 women, Health Minister Rakan Nassereddine said on Sunday. He also said that nine rescue workers were among the dead. AFP

Political prisoners released in Venezuela since Maduro's ouster

621 Venezuela released 17 political prisoners on Saturday from a jail in the capital, Caracas, as a new law granted amnesty for crimes historically used to lock up dissidents. AFP
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Why did U.S. SC reject Trump's tariffs?

What authority did the Trump administration rely on to impose tariffs? Can Trump still impose tariffs after the ruling? What role does Congress play in tariff powers? Will businesses receive refunds for the tariffs they paid? Does the ruling limit future Presidents' trade powers?

EXPLAINER

Areena Arora

The story so far:

In February 20, the U.S. Supreme Court delivered a decision that could reshape the legal boundaries of presidential trade power. The court held that the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA), which U.S. President Donald Trump relied on, does not authorise a President to impose tariffs. It struck down the sweeping reciprocal and drug-trafficking-related tariffs imposed by Mr. Trump in 2025, calling them unconstitutional.

What authority did Trump rely on?

So far, Mr. Trump has used the IEEPA, a 1977 law that allows the President to regulate certain economic transactions after declaring a national emergency to address an “unusual and extraordinary threat” originating outside the country. IEEPA emerged out of the Trading with the Enemy Act, which was passed in 1917 when the U.S. entered the First World War, to regulate trade with enemy nations. It has been used to freeze foreign assets held in American banks, block financial transfers, and impose sanctions on hostile governments and terrorist groups. However, before 2025, it was never used to impose tariffs.

After returning to office for his second term, Mr. Trump declared national emergencies tied to drug trafficking from Latin American countries and trade imbalances. His administration imposed 25% tariffs on most goods from its neighbours, Canada and Mexico, 10% tariffs on most goods from China, and a separate reciprocal tariff programme imposing at least a 10% duty on imports from virtually all trading partners. Some countries, including India, were hit with even higher rates.



GETTY IMAGES

Why did the Supreme Court strike the tariffs down?

The U.S. Constitution gives Congress the power “to lay and collect taxes, duties, imposts and excises.” Congress also has the power to regulate trade with foreign countries, and tariffs fall squarely within that authority.

The court concluded in a 6-3 ruling that the IEEPA does not authorise the President to impose tariffs. Chief Justice John Roberts, in his opinion, cited a hodgepodge of tariffs announced by Mr. Trump.

“The President asserts the extraordinary power to unilaterally impose tariffs of unlimited amount, duration, and scope,” Justice Roberts wrote in his opinion. “In light of the breadth, history, and constitutional context of that asserted authority, he must identify clear congressional authorisation to exercise it.”

Does this mean Trump can no longer impose tariffs?

No. The decision only forbids the use of IEEPA, but Mr. Trump was quick to announce a workaround. Shortly after the

Supreme Court ruling, his administration announced a new temporary import duty, which went into effect on February 24 for a period of 150 days.

“We will get back to the same tariff level for the countries. It will just be in a less direct and slightly more convoluted manner,” U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said after the Supreme Court ruling.

Mr. Trump alluded to using Sections 122, 301, and 232 to levy tariffs.

Section 122 is part of the Trade Act of 1974. It permits the U.S. President to impose tariffs of up to 15% on a country to address “a large and serious United States balance-of-payments deficit.” The tariff can be applied for a maximum of 150 days unless extended by Congress.

Section 301 of the U.S. Trade Act of 1974 allows tariffs to be imposed if the government finds that a trading partner has engaged in what it deems unfair trade practices.

Section 232 is part of the U.S. Trade Expansion Act of 1962. These tariffs are levied on specific sectors if the Secretary of Commerce deems them necessary on national security grounds.

What role does Congress now play?

Congress sits at the centre of tariff authority for two reasons.

The Constitution assigns it the taxing power, and in its ruling, the court leaned heavily on this allocation while interpreting the IEEPA.

Congress determines the scope of executive trade authority through statute. It has the power to narrow existing delegations, require its approval for tariffs, or even expand presidential powers if it chooses to.

Politically, redesigning tariff authority would require bipartisan agreement, especially since the court has made clear that sweeping tariffs must rest on a clear legislative footing.

Will businesses that lost money to tariffs get refunds?

For months, American businesses and customers bore the brunt of the heightened tariffs. The court ruling, while rendering the tariffs illegal, has not created a mechanism for a refund.

According to a Goldman Sachs report, \$180 billion was collected through the now-invalidated tariffs.

More than 1,000 companies, including big names like FedEx, have sued the U.S. government in the U.S. Court of International Trade seeking refunds for the tariffs.

The suit is seeking compensation for potentially millions of shippers who paid import duties and related fees on products that should have entered the U.S. duty-free, *Reuters* reported.

Does the court decision limit future Presidents?

The ruling draws a clearer statutory boundary.

Future Presidents will retain the authority to regulate trade, as Mr. Trump does, but courts rely heavily on precedents. As a result, it may scrutinise attempts to use emergency powers beyond their intended scope.

THE GIST

▼ The Supreme Court of the United States held that the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) does not authorise the President to impose tariffs, striking down the sweeping tariffs imposed by Donald Trump in 2025.

▼ The court ruled that tariffs fall under Congress's power to lay and collect taxes and regulate trade with foreign countries, and that the President must identify clear congressional authorisation to impose them.

Why are Finance Commission grants to cities still so limited?

Can cities plan their future when most funds are tied to Central conditions?

Tikender Singh Panwar

The story so far:

Cities continue to be the excruciating centres of capital accumulation at an unprecedented pace. Around 90% of total government revenue and nearly 67% of the country's GDP is generated through urban centres. Yet the recommendations of the 16th Finance Commission (FC) emphasise that cities must find avenues to increase their own source revenue and expand the tax base, even as the overall devolution of funds to urban local bodies remains limited.

What do the numbers reveal?

Under the 15th FC, urban local bodies received roughly ₹1.2-1.3 lakh crore over five years. India's GDP during that period hovered around ₹200-210 lakh crore. The urban transfer, therefore, amounted to approximately 0.12-0.13% of GDP.

Under the 16th FC, urban local bodies are to receive around ₹3.56 lakh crore between 2026 and 2031. This translates to roughly ₹75,000 crore per year, far from

adequate for urban transformation. India's GDP by then is projected at roughly ₹400 lakh crore, which means the ratio remains almost unchanged at roughly 0.13% of GDP.

Another catch is defining the ‘urban’. The data is drawn from multiple sources which estimate that the urban population will reach around 41% by 2031. In simple terms, this means that per capita devolution does not change significantly.

The illusion deepens when per capita figures are introduced. India's urban population crossed 470 million around 2020 and is projected to approach or exceed 600 million during the 2026-30 FC cycle. When urban grants are distributed across this expanded demographic base, per capita transfers stagnate and may even decline in real terms.

Another issue concerns the utilisation of funds. Under the 15th FC, total grants to local bodies amounted to around ₹4.36 lakh crore. Yet a substantial portion remained unspent or pending utilisation, estimated at roughly ₹90,000-95,000 crore, including about ₹30,000-35,000

crore meant for urban local bodies.

What are tied grants?

Tied grants for cities refer to funds earmarked for specific sectors such as water supply, sanitation, and wastewater management, etc. Tied grants hamper fiscal autonomy because States – and cities – are required to spend the funds only on these specified categories.

The approach of the 16th FC is even more aggressive, leaving less space for cities to use funds, as they are also subject to performance-based grants, which means the grants will be released only when certain performance criteria are met. These include improving fiscal discipline, ensuring the proper constitution of local bodies through regular elections, publishing provisional and audited accounts in the public domain, and constituting State Finance Commissions.

All of these are reasonable. However, the problem arises when 20% of the funds are linked to additional conditions, failing which cities will not receive that share. The key condition relates to increasing

own source revenue (OSR) through property taxes and user charges. The benchmark kept by the FC is to raise ₹1,200 per household through such revenues.

Why does it raise federal concerns?

A sum of ₹10,000 crore is kept for the one-time incentive for peri-urban merger of urban villages with a population of more than one lakh.

This has two major problems. First, urban development is constitutionally a State subject, and a federal intervention to induce such a transition is dangerous, as merging the peripheries of just 10% of urban towns may translate into lopsided urban integration, with the primary aim being to generate own source revenues. Second, in many States, take for example Kerala, where rural local governments function robustly, merging rural areas into urban agglomerations could create administrative and civic complications. The 16th FC also remains largely silent on climate change and pays little attention to the growing pool of cess revenues collected by the Centre and kept outside the divisible pool. These cess collections now amount to around 2.2% of GDP – roughly ₹8.8 lakh crore. Much of this revenue is generated from cities, yet it still does not appear in the OSR.

The 16th FC appears to miss a basic fibre in the entire exercise: “let cities plan their own futures,” while the Centre acts as an enabler. After all, it is their money, and they have a legitimate right to its utilisation. (*Tikender Singh Panwar is a member of the Kerala Urban Commission*)

THE GIST

▼ Despite urban centres generating a large share of GDP and government revenue, the devolution of funds to urban local bodies remains limited, with transfers continuing at around 0.13% of GDP.

▼ The 16th Finance Commission links a portion of urban grants to performance conditions and increasing own source revenue, raising concerns about fiscal autonomy and federal intervention in urban development.

AI-generated videos of animals can damage our very relationship with wildlife. REUTERS

AI-generated animal videos are spreading across social media as generative AI tools allow users to create hyper-realistic clips and chase virality; but these fake wildlife encounters can warp public perception of animal behaviour, spread misinformation, and potentially harm humans and animals

Sahana Venugopal

The story so far:

pen up Instagram, Meta AI, TikTok, YouTube Shorts, or X on your phone and it won't be long before you scroll to a short video clip that shows animals and humans sharing a bizarre encounter.

While an AI-generated video of a man taking an underwater selfie with a shark is easy to identify as fake, more realistic generative AI videos can warp the way we think about wild animals and their behavioural traits, putting both them and us in danger.

Why are AI animal deepfakes on the rise?

This is thanks to a barrage of Generative AI tools that allow users to enter text prompts in everyday language and churn out hyper-realistic videos at scale that can be easily uploaded online.

As platforms like Meta pivot to short-form videos in an attempt to surpass TikTok, while X rewards virality and engagement, users are incentivised to make and share more low-cost, low-effort content.

As a result, you might have seen gorillas breaking out of zoo enclosures, crocodiles gobbling up their handlers, dying lions surrendering their cubs to humans, fishermen rescuing polar bears, and monkeys dancing with children.

These videos are generally called “AI

slop” due to their low-grade entertainment value and short length. Often shared with sensationalised captions or presented as though they are real news events, viewers inevitably waste their time trying to figure out if the content is real or AI-generated.

Violence is also a major pull factor in AI animal videos: a giraffe is decapitated by an overhead bridge, a gorilla smashes a tiger with a boulder, a hippo excretes in the face of another animal with the power of a missile, a crazed shark mauls a swimmer, and a whale swims after a desperate Arctic fox.

Such videos come with or without melodramatic storylines. These are reshared, repeated, and re-adapted by others hoping to go viral.

What harm can AI animal videos cause?

AI-generated animal videos rack up millions of views on platforms like X and YouTube, because they are seen by viewers across age groups and with varying levels of media education and digital literacy. In essence, AI animal videos can change our relationships with animals.

For example, a video of a little girl feeding puppies or a boy dancing with a monkey on Meta AI might seem like harmless, heartwarming slop, but they downplay the dangers of parents letting their children approach unvetted animals without expert supervision, especially in

a country struggling to tackle rabies.

Research in this area is ongoing, but a September 2025 report titled ‘Threats to conservation from artificial-intelligence-generated wildlife images and videos’ [Conservation Biology, 40, e70138] explores how AI images and videos of animals might undermine conservation efforts by spreading misinformation.

According to the report, AI animal videos can make social media users believe that endangered/vulnerable creatures are actually easy to find around them. Exposure to inaccurate AI animal videos could also confuse children on social media, and set back efforts to identify diverse types of animals or tell apart native species.

Other possible outcomes outlined in the report could directly harm animals. These include overtourism due to AI-generated animal sightings, spreading the false idea that animals have human behavioural traits such as affection for children (known as anthropomorphism), or making exotic pets look attractive in spite of laws prohibiting wildlife trafficking.

“Some AI videos depict interspecific interactions that are implausible, for example, affiliative behaviours between animals of different species, including between predators and prey, and between parasites and hosts. Some videos depict friendships between humans and wild animals, which can be dangerous if,

in an encounter with an animal, a human fails to recognize it as a potential threat,” noted the paper’s authors.

How do conservation groups feel about AI?

The responsible application of generative AI technology definitely helps out experts in the conservation sector, according to Dipankar Ghose, Senior Director-Biodiversity Conservation, at WWF-India.

The organisation is using AI to identify images of large mammals caught by camera traps and segregate hundreds of them by their species in a matter of minutes. If done manually, this process would have taken days. AI is also used for bioacoustics and creating data-driven content.

However, Ghose was strongly against AI videos of animals made for entertainment.

“It is a dangerous trend in which AI is used to create hyper-realistic clips of tigers picking up people from their beds or leopards drinking water from a kid’s water bottle, all completely fake!” he explained.

“It is a nightmare for conservationists and wildlife and forest managers, particularly the officers and field staff of state forest departments and administration, as public perception can be manipulated by these fake videos, which may result in retaliatory violence against wild animals.”

The worst damage a weapon can inflict in a war need not be nuclear. The firebombings of World War II show this vividly

Please send in your answers to
dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

Vasudevan Mukunth

QUESTION 1

On March 9-10, Allied forces firebombed _____ in the deadliest single air raid in human history and which also became part of a broader military strategy that defined warfare in the mid-20th century. Fill in the blank.

QUESTION 2

The deadliest effect of a firebombing is the _____, which forms when multiple fires come together. It is, however, named for its ability to sustain its own micro-weather system, which heats it up and drives winds inwards for it to consume, making it nearly impossible to put out. Fill in the blank.

QUESTION 3

In 2003, the U.S. used X, whose composition has been called a successor to napalm. While napalm bombs contained a mix of

benzene, gasoline, and polystyrene, X is kerosene-based and uses less benzene. Name X, which the U.S. used to fiery effect in the early stages of the 2003 Iraq War.

QUESTION 4

The main way in which a firebombing kills people is not by burning them. Instead, the fires consume so much oxygen from the air that people, even those inside air-raid shelters, suffocate. The fires also produce large amounts of Y, which seeps into underground bunkers and kills those inside. Name Y.

QUESTION 5

During a firebombing, before the military drops the incendiary cannisters, it drops explosives to blow off roofs and shatter windows and to rupture the water mains. While the first two expose structures' wooden interiors and other flammable surfaces, the third one is to prevent firefighters from doing what?



In one of history's most controversial raids and which has been called a war crime, Allied bombers firebombed this city in February 1945, incinerating its historic centre and killing at least around 25,000 people. Name it. BUNDESARCHIV (CC BY-SA)

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. X is a sculpture by Michelangelo. It captures the moment when Jesus was taken down from the cross and given to Mary. **Ans: The Pietà**

2. Michelangelo's most famous sculpture is arguably the statue of David. Where was it originally supposed to be located? **Ans: Florence Cathedral**

3. What does a salad made of mozzarella, tomatoes, basil, and olive oil, and the birthplace of Michelangelo have in common? **Ans: Both are called Caprese**

4. Michelangelo and X were commissioned to paint battle scenes in competition with one another, but neither of them finished their work. Who is X? **Ans: Leonardo da Vinci**

5. On the Sistine Chapel altar wall, Michelangelo depicted himself as X. **Ans: St Bartholomew**

Visual: Who is this man, whom Michelangelo chose to depict fondling his beard, with flowing hair, and horns? **Ans: Moses**

Early Birds: Tito Shiladitya | Erfanally Oosmany | Swastika | Arun Kumar Singh | Prodish Mitra



KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

*The professor's
lecture was
pedestrian*

Thinking you will top the exam
without studying is building
castles in the air

S. Upendran

"Where have you disappeared to? I don't see you in the gym in the evenings anymore. Everyone has been asking about you."

"I go to the gym in the mornings, nowadays. I'm taking sitar lessons in the evenings."

"Had no idea that you were interested in learning to play sitar. How long..."

"It's 'play the sitar' and not 'play sitar'. Remember that most musical instruments are usually preceded by the indefinite article. For example, Revathi learnt to play the guitar over ten years ago."

"Jagdish plays the flute. How's that?"

"Sounds good! The guy who played the violin was really good."

"While we're on the subject of the violin, I heard your favourite group's new song yesterday. What do you think of it?"

"Compared to some of their earlier songs, this one was pedestrian."

"Pedestrian? What are you talking about?"

"The word 'pedestrian' has different meanings. One of them, as you've rightly pointed out, is someone who is on foot."

"The pedestrian was run over by a speeding car."

"In addition to people, the word can also be used to talk about movies, novels, a piece of writing, etc."

"Really? But how can you call a movie 'pedestrian'?"

"When you say that a movie was 'pedestrian', what you're suggesting is that it was dull!"

"In other words, there was no creative spark."

"Very good! Here's an example. The Minister's speech was pedestrian."

"How about this example? The themes that the writer deals with are rather pedestrian."

"Sounds good! The word is pronounced pe-DES-tri-en, by the way. The stress is on the second syllable."

"So, tell me. Do you think you'll be able to master the sitar in a couple of months?"

"If I said, 'Yes', I'd probably be building castles in the air."

"Building castles in the air? Are you saying that it has very little chance of happening?"

"Very good! When you 'build castles in the air', you're coming up with plans which have no chance of succeeding."

"Plans which are unlikely to be carried out!"

"My young nephew believes that five years from now, he'll become a famous movie star. If you ask me, he's building castles in the air."

"That's what all young people do."

"Even old people do it. My grandfather would spend the evenings sitting in his rocking chair, building castles in the air."

"Did you ever ask him what he was building?"

"Asked him once, but he merely chuckled. Oh, by the way, it's also possible to say 'build castles in Spain'. Instead of building castles in Spain, you should come up with a reasonable plan to solve your financial problem."

"Where's the fun in that?"

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Word of the day

Deride:
treat or speak of with contempt

Synonyms: ridicule, mock, insult

Usage: *Some people deride new ideas without thinking.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/deridepro

International Phonetic Alphabet: /dɪrɑːd/

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Text & Context, please write to
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